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Virginia Board of Education, Business Meeting, Thursday, September 25, 2025

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=qKXzHdvyc6o
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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[00:06:45] Good morning. It is 9.02. I will now call this meeting to order. As is customary for the board, we will begin our meeting with a moment of silence followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

[00:07:17] I pledge allegiance to the plaque of the United States of America and to the republic for which it stands, one nation, under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all.

[00:07:30] I will note that I have approved the remote participation of Mr. Bill Hansen under the board's bylaws and 2.2-3708.3 B1 of the Code of Virginia because the member named has been given the opportunity to, let's see, the principal residence is more than 60 miles away from the meeting location and because of a personal matter.

[00:08:05] he is participating remotely. Okay. Moving on. We'd like to approve our agenda this morning. So is there a motion to approve the agenda as presented? So move. Second. Dr. Ackerman. Aye.

[00:08:22] Mr. Green. Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Mr. Hanson. Can you hear me? Okay. Ms. McPherson. Aye. Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Ms. Ashton. Aye. Mr. Monk. Aye. Chair votes aye. Okay. Staff has presented the members of the board with the draft minutes before the meeting. Is there a motion to approve the minutes as presented to the board? So moved. Second. Dr. Ackerman. Aye. Mr. Green. Aye. Dr. Northern.

[00:08:59] Mr. Hanson. Aye. Ms. McPherson. Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Ms. Ashton. Aye. Mr. Monk. Aye. And chair votes aye. Okay. As is customary with all of our board meetings, we appreciate being able to feature wonderful arts programs from across the Commonwealth by having students perform at our meetings.

[00:09:21] And I will now ask Ms. Ashton if she will provide us with an introduction of our guests. Ms. Ashton? I'd be so excited to do that. Thank you, Chair. The Appomattox Regional Governor's School for Arts and Technology, ARGS, located in Petersburg, Virginia, serves 14 school divisions ranging from Amelia to Southern Hampton counties.

[00:09:44] ARGS, founded in 1999, is a full-time high school where students are able to combine their talents in the arts with an education that goes beyond the minimum curriculum. Alumni from ARGS have performed on Broadway, been nominated for Tony Awards, and have been accepted to dance companies around the world. Under the direction of dance faculty member Taylor Black, students will perform two pieces. Before I Sleep by Maisie Starr and I Got You Babe by Sonny and Cher. We know that song.

[00:10:20] The first piece, a duet choreographed by Tallulah Shamel and Trinity Shank will be performed by Tallulah Shamel and Brian Hawkins. Is that right? Brianne. Brynn, thank you for correcting. Brynn Hawkins. Tallulah, Trinity, and Brynn are current juniors in the ARGS dance department and choreographed this piece at the end of their sophomore year as a part of their weight sharing unit on their on their modern dance course. The second piece is an excerpt from a work in progress in their repertory and performance class where dancers learn about rehearsal and performance skills.

[00:11:00] This piece will be choreographed by ARGS Dance Department Chair Taylor Black and will be performed by three seniors, go seniors. Lena Robinson, is it Dania, Daniel Walker and Kaya Williams.

[00:11:17] Wonderful, shall we? Yes, thank you.

[00:13:07] And I hate you, I'm very, and I'm so sorry. I'm gonna stay here and wait for my time. Just wait for my time.

[00:16:30] But it is all strange, I guess that snow will never fly, but at least I'm sure of all the things we got, they grew up, I got you please, I got you please, I got you please, I got flowers, in the spring, I got you, and where my friends go, I'll get you, I can't get you wrong.

[00:17:31] I have the distinct honor of presenting the 2025 Presidential Award for Excellence in

[00:23:22] Mathematics and Science Teaching state-level finalist. The Virginia Board of Education is pleased to recognize five secondary mathematics and science teachers as the 2025 state-level finalists for the Presidential Awards for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Teaching.

[00:23:40] The PAMST program, established in 1983, is administered by the National Science Foundation on behalf of the White House Office of Science and Technology. The Presidential Awards for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Teaching are the highest honors bestowed by the United States government specifically for K-12 Science, Technology, Engineering, Mathematics, and/or Computer Science Teaching. The program identifies outstanding teachers from each of the 50 states and the four United States jurisdictions. The award recognizes those teachers who have deep content

[00:24:15] knowledge of the subjects they teach and the ability to motivate and enable students to be successful in those areas. The awards alternate each year between elementary teachers in kindergarten through grade six and secondary teachers in grade seven through 12.

[00:24:32] The PAEMST awardees serve as models for their colleagues and are leaders in the improvement of STEM education. We are honored to recognize the following teachers as the 2025 PAEMST state level finalist for the Commonwealth of Virginia. Mathematics finalist, Ms. Jennifer Fehan. Ms.

[00:24:52] Jennifer Fehan is a mathematics teacher at Fauquier High School and Fauquier County Public Schools. During her time at Fauquier High School, Ms. Fehan has taught many different mathematics classes including Algebra I, Geometry, AP, Calculus, BC, and Multivariable Calculus. She works hard to incorporate movement activities and communication into each one of her classes. Students routinely get up and do problems on whiteboards, go into the hallway for a gallery walk or scavenger hunt, or have group discussions about how to approach math problems. Ms. Feehan prides herself on creating an interactive classroom, noting that it's the best part of her classroom. Ms. Feehan

[00:25:32] also engages in activities outside the classroom to improve her teaching and support her local community. She has recently finished her master's degree in education with a focus on mathematics. Congratulations on that one. She found her classes to be valuable in helping her to use project-based assessments in the classroom effectively, access mathematical dialogue, and give meaningful summative assessments to students.

[00:25:57] Ms. Feehan also serves as a mentor for other students, helping them with classroom management and strategies to engage students. Ms. Feehan's peers recognized her outstanding contributions by nominating her for Teacher of the Year for the 2024-25 school year.

[00:26:14] The school's assistant principal, Ms. Colleen Robson, states that Ms. Feehan played a crucial role during the transition to virtual learning in the spring and fall of 2020 by helping her colleagues establish their online classrooms, demonstrating her commitment to the entire department.

[00:26:31] Furthermore, she noted that Ms. Feehan employs innovative teaching strategies to ensure that her students experience success. Ms. Feehan's passion for teaching is unparalleled, and her dedication to her craft is undeniably undeniably among the best I have supervised. So on behalf of the Board of Education, I recognize Ms. Jennifer Fehan from Fauquier High School for the 2025 Presidential Award for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Teaching as a Mathematics State-Level Finalist.

[00:27:05] Mr. John Micah. Mr. Micah is not able to attend the Board of Education Recognition event. However, we would like to recognize and celebrate his achievements. Mr. John Micah is a Mathematics teacher at Hayfield Secondary School in Fairfax County Public Schools. He has been in education for more than 45 years and in his current position for more than 20 years. Mr. Fika uses a combination of storytelling, Socratic seminars, and whiteboards to engage his students in learning every day.

[00:27:45] In fact, he has had students tell him that they remembered a concept because of a story he shared in class. Mr. Mika is dedicated to supporting students beyond the school day. During the last 10 years, he has had the opportunity to be a reader for the AP Statistics exam, which he notes has been the best professional development opportunity he has experienced. Additionally, Mr. Micah typically stays after school for several hours each day, allowing time for students to come for help or to hang out. Mr. Micah uses his time to recruit students to rural mathematics classes.

[00:28:20] Since teaching in Fairfax County, he has proposed and been approved to add a non-AP probability of statistics and applied calculus courses at his school. Mr. Brian Oliver, the math department chairperson, states that Mr. Micah possesses an exceptional mastery of calculus and statistics.

[00:28:38] His deep understanding of the curriculum allows him to present complex concepts in ways that are accessible and engaging to students. Joseph Kearns, a former student and current colleague of Mr. Micah's, adds, beyond his work inside the classroom, Mr. Micah is deeply committed to helping students outside of school hours, whether providing additional support through office hours, sponsoring clubs, or simply offering advice to students who need guidance. He goes above and beyond to ensure that every student has the resources they need to succeed, and he will be receiving his certificate

[00:29:13] later. And now for our science finalist, Mr. Russell Coors. Mr. Russell Coors is a science teacher in Massinetton Regional Governor's School for the Integrated Environmental Science and Technology of Virginia Academic Year Governor School. Mr. Kors teaches dual-enrolled environmental science courses and serves as a faculty mentor for student research, fostering a program deeply rooted in collaboration, critical thinking, and real-world problem solving. His classroom emphasizes interdisciplinary learning, where students engage in authentic projects such as

[00:29:48] sustainable building design, field research, and problem-based learning experiences that connect science with mathematics, English, and engineering. Beyond his classroom, Mr. Kors serves as a master teacher and a curriculum designer with the Virginia Space Grant Consortium, guiding students statewide in programs like the Virginia Aerospace Science and Technology Scholars and the Virginia Earth System Science Scholars, including summer academies at NASA Langley. His professional expertise is also recognized through his adjunct faculty role at Virginia Community College, contributions to statewide SOL test development,

[00:30:27] and extensive professional service with organizations such as the Virginia Association of Science Teachers, where he currently serves as president. Mr. Cordes has been honored with numerous awards, including the Donna Sterling Exemplary Science Teacher Award, the National Association of Geoscience Teachers Outstanding Earth Science Teacher of Virginia, and the Eastern section and the Dorothy Stout Professional Development Award. His colleagues know his creativity, passion, and ability to inspire students, whether leading fieldwork, co-teaching interdisciplinary projects, or mentoring students in authentic research. As one colleague described,

[00:31:06] "If Russ is involved, we can be sure that passion, creativity, and enthusiasm are in the mix." So, Mr. Kors, on behalf of the Board of Education, I'd like to present you with the mass um the excuse me the 2025 presidential award for excellence in mathematics and science teaching and your science state level finalists congratulations next we have miss kirsten

[00:31:41] salonga miss kirsten salonga is a science teacher at justice high school and fairfax county public schools where she also serves as science department chair and mentor to new educators in her classroom she teaches in environmental science multilingual learners in grades 9 through 12th, designing lessons that emphasize hands-on inquiry, scaffolding, and collaboration. She is committed to teaching science as a process of drawing conclusions from evidence, creating innovative lab activities that are now used across her department and neighboring schools.

[00:32:14] Ms. Salonga's students engage in meaningful investigations of the properties of water, hydroponic systems, and environmental stewardship projects, with supports that ensure language learners can thrive and succeed in rigorous science learning. Ms. Salonga extends her impact far beyond her classroom. She has engaged in NSF-funded research experiences at Michigan State University's Kellogg

Biological Station, where she contributed to genetics research on—I don't have to pronounce this word here—Arobidopsis. Learned a new word today and

[00:32:49] co-developed data nuggets to present authentic research into classrooms nationwide. She has learned prestigious, she has earned prestigious national recognition from the National Science Teachers Association and the National Geographic Society. Her leadership is evident in her department chair role, her mentoring colleagues, and her presentations at national conferences on multilingual science education. As her assistant principal describes Mrs. Salonga, Ms. Salonga brings an unparalleled level of energy to everything she does, fostering a culture of

[00:33:21] collaboration and equity for both students and teachers. On behalf of the Board of Education, I present Kirsten Salonga of Justin High School, Fairfax County Public Schools with a 2025 Presidential Award for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Teaching as a state-level finalist.

[00:33:42] And last but not least, we have Mr. Daryl Smith. Mr. Daryl Smith is a seventh grade life science teacher at Alta Vista Combined School in Campbell County Public Schools. With more than 20 years of service, he has dedicated his career to inspiring students to see themselves as scientists. His classroom is built on inquiry, exploration, and critical thinking. Rather than relying on worksheets, students construct data tables, test hypotheses, and engage in meaningful science-centered

[00:34:22] conversations with their peers. Through labs, outdoor learning, and real-world applications, He engages students to ask questions, solve problems and take ownership of their learning. Many of his students remember him as the best science teacher they ever had. Mr. Smith's instructional style emphasizes authentic learning and community connections. He creates interactive projects and field-based experiences that foster curiosity and make science relevant to students' lives. His collaborations with the James River Association and the Holiday Lake 4-H Center

[00:34:57] provides students with unique opportunities in an environmental science. He has also secured grants such as the National Park Service Get Outside grant and the Keystone grant to enhance outdoor education, giving his students immersive experiences in nature. His ability to spark interest reaches even reluctant learners, with this principal noting that it is not uncommon to see him after school working with Tier 3 students who once had a little interest in science.

[00:35:26] Beyond the classroom, Mr. Smith has been science department chair since 2018, leading curriculum development, mentoring colleagues, and facilitating professional learning. He is also a standout track and cross-country coach, inducted into the AltaVista Hall of Fame for his achievements.

[00:35:44] His leadership, both in academics and athletics, reflects his dedication to developing students' minds and character. As his principal stated, anyone who spends time in his classroom will see the gift that he uses every day. So on behalf of the Board of Education I would like to present Mr.

[00:36:01] Darrell Smith from Alta Vista Combined Schools Campbell County Public Schools the 2025 Presidential Award for Excellence in Mathematics and Science Teaching as a science state level finalist. Congratulations. Thank you. Thank you all and before I move to our next presentation I just want to say we are so thankful for all of you who not only serve as role models for your students but but more importantly, serve as role models for your colleagues, serve as mentors for

[00:36:38] your colleagues, and then also shine a beacon of light for the profession within your communities. So we are so thankful for you, all of you, and the work that you do that is so tireless, and we

recognize that. And so please just know how deeply we appreciate you in every single moment that you give to our profession and to the students of the Commonwealth.

[00:37:01] So thank you so much. At this time, I would ask Ms. McPherson if she would present our next award.

[00:37:37] Good morning, everyone. We have amazing staff members at the Virginia Department of Education, but today we want to highlight a few for the extraordinary work that they did in recognition of the Emmy award-winning series, Virginia Roots, A Journey into Appalachian Music.

[00:38:02] So today we are honored to recognize an extraordinary collaboration that celebrates Virginia's cultural heritage and enriches our classrooms, Virginia Roots, A Journey into Appalachian Music. The Emmy Award winning series is a co-production of Blue Ridge PBS, PBS Appalachian Virginia, and the Virginia Department of Education.

[00:38:27] The series was awarded the Emmy for informational and instructional long-form content by the National Academy of Television Arts and Sciences National Capital Chesapeake Bay Chapter, a prestigious recognition of its educational value and creative excellence.

[00:38:48] Virginia Roots was created to support music educators in integrating traditional Appalachian music into school curriculum. The series includes five short videos that explore the history and culture behind the music, musicians, instruments, and playing techniques of old time and bluegrass traditions.

[00:39:10] Accompany instructional materials available on the website, Traditional Music and Arts YouTube, the Emmy-winning videos are shown there. The accompanying instructional materials are also available on the music instruction page of the Virginia Department of Education website, including the episode descriptions, discussion prompts, and alignment to the 2020 Music Standards of Learning.

[00:39:39] These resources were developed in collaboration with Virginia music educators. We would like to recognize these dedicated Virginia Department of Education staff members who contributed to this award-winning and Emmy award-winning project.

[00:39:57] First, Calypso Gilstrap, the Executive Director, Office of Innovation. Mr. Gilstrap, if you come forward, or Ms. Gilstrap, my apologies. Calypso. Those people call me Calypso. That's right. On behalf of the Virginia Board of Education, we present you with the Certificate of Recognition for the Emmy for Informational and Instructional Long-Form Content by the National Academy of Television Arts and Sciences National Chesapeake Bay Chapter, adopted in Richmond, Virginia, this 25th day of September in the year 2025.

[00:40:33] Thank you so much, and congratulations. Thank you. Next, Kelly Bisagno. Oh, and they have their certificates and trophies. Oh, how nice. We love it. They're gorgeous. Okay. So, Ms. Bisagno, as a fine arts coordinator with the Virginia Department of Education, we present you with a certificate of recognition for your contribution to the Emmy for informational and instructional long-form content that was awarded by the National Academy of Television Arts and Sciences,

[00:41:13] the National Chesapeake Bay Chapter, adopted in Virginia this 25th day of September 2025. Thank you so much and congratulations. Well deserved. Sherry Hatton. Ms. Hatton, on behalf of the Virginia Board of Education, we present you with this certificate of recognition presented to you as a fine

arts specialist by the Virginia Department of Education for your contribution in collaboration with the Emmy Award winning program, Virginia Roots, awarded by the National

[00:41:52] Academy of Television Arts and Sciences, National Chesapeake Bay Chapter, adopted in Richmond, Virginia, this 25th day of September of the year 2025. Thank you so much for your contributions as well. Congratulations. We would also now like to recognize the Creative Blue Ridge PBS staff who produced this project. Please come forward, Mr. Tom Landon.

[00:42:23] Oh, Mr. Nandan, congratulations. On behalf of the Virginia Board of Education, we present you with this certificate of recognition for your work as a Director of Educational Innovation at Blue Ridge PBS for the award-winning series "Virginia Roots" presented by the National Academy of Television Arts and Sciences National Chesapeake Bay Chapter, adopted in Richmond, Virginia, this 25th day of September 2025. Thank you so much. They couldn't have done it without you.

[00:42:53] all right mr j prater mr prater on behalf of the virginia board of education we also present to you the certificate of recognition presented to you as the producer blue ridge pbs for assisting in the award-winning certificate that was awarded and trophies and certificates of recognition awarded in the emmy for information instructional long-form content provided this 25th day of of September 2025 in Richmond, Virginia.

[00:43:28] Thank you so much for the production and the contribution that you do with us.

[00:43:36] - Thank you all.

[00:44:19] - Okay, as stated in the board's bylaws, it's the pleasure of the board to accept public comment on all matters related to public education in Virginia. Before we begin today, I would wanna share a few comments with you about the manner in which we will have public comment conducted.

[00:44:38] I ask that you model professionalism, dignity and respect for others as you share your thoughts. As adults, it's important that we model respectful civil public discourse for our students and children who are either in attendance today or could be watching online now or in the future. When you begin, please provide your name, your role or affiliation, and where you live in Virginia. All remarks must be directed to the chair and not to any other individual. Speakers will have three minutes to share their remarks. You will notice there is a timer on the computer screen over here on the table. At three minutes, it is green. At

[00:45:15] one minute, it is yellow. The screen will turn red when your time is up, and we ask that you promptly close your remarks at that time. Speakers may provide any copies of their remarks to Mr. Joe Crook. Joe's raising his hand now. All written comments received during the public comment period will be collected and provided to the board as soon as possible. You may also email a copy of your remarks to the board at B-O-E at D-O-E dot Virginia, B-I-R-G-I-N-I-A dot gov. And with that,

[00:45:49] we will begin with Scott Braebrand, followed by Candace Lucas. Superintendent Gullickson, President Creasy, and members of the Board of Education, my name is Scott Braebrand. I'm Executive Director for the Virginia Association of School Superintendents, and I live in Lynchburg, Virginia. On behalf of Virginia School Superintendents, we wish to express with the Virginia Board of Education, our shared commitment to maintaining exceptionally high expectations for all students. We support rigorous academic standards that ensure young people are prepared for college careers and life by the time they graduate high school. At the same time, the process

[00:46:26] through which new standards of running cut scores are determined must be fair, transparent, and data driven. Both the Board of Ed and the public were assured that the Department of Ed would provide impact modeling of these proposed higher cut scores, and that modeling is essential, both for the board members making these critical decisions and our school divisions and families who are seeking to understand how students will be affected. We ask the board, respectfully ask the board to complete this impact analysis and share it publicly before approving any final cut score decisions. Additionally, results of the analysis should guide the development of a comprehensive system of supports for students and school divisions. Although higher expectations are

[00:47:06] welcomed, they must be paired with the resources, strategies, and tools to allow educators to meet the needs of all students. Divisions need time and clarity to plan targeted interventions and build supports that students can meet new benchmarks. To that end, we recommend a phased-in approach to implementing the proposed higher cut scores. An eight-year stair-step increase would provide a feasible pathway for students, teachers, and school divisions to adjust while maintaining the state's high academic standards. This measured approach would enable schools to adapt their instruction, align resources, and ensure the success of students as the new standards are established.

[00:47:42] This type of approach will offer more time to provide additional office of school quality supports, maximize funding streams, develop communication plans, and incorporate a new growth model to replace Vivos. Finally, it's worth noting the dynamics of state-level accountability and personalized student growth. The state's role is to set expectations, measure performance and ensure public accountability. The role of school divisions is to meet students where they are, use data strategically, and provide targeted instruction to maximize each student's growth. By phasing in higher cut scores with the appropriate levels of transparency and

[00:48:19] support, we can meet both goals, providing accountability to the public while keeping the individual growth of every student at the center of our collective work. Thank you for your consideration of these perspectives and for your continued dedication to advancing educational excellence here in the Commonwealth of Virginia for all children. Thank you.

[00:48:42] Candice Lucas, followed by Cheryl Sims. It's always too tall for me. Good morning, board members. My name is Dr. Candice Lucas. I'm an activist as well as an individual who is coming before you, has come before you repeatedly to address the issues of inequity as it pertains of students with disabilities as well as students of color um emily and grace i sent you guys an

[00:49:16] email yesterday because i was appalled at the fact that emily was going make a public comment about charlie kirk stating anyone who would suggest the heinous murder of the father of two young children is acceptable should be disqualified from teaching and working with children again and emily my question is how can you stand up for charlie kirk and you're not standing up for black children with disabilities in virginia no one's standing up for them in my mind i would say that anyone who commits violence against black children and children with

[00:49:54] disabilities denying them access to a free and appropriate education should be disqualified from teaching in fact that is what the code says the code does not say and i'm going to go back to that code the code does not state that if you criticize charlie kirk you lose your license what the code states is if you falsify records which they do we've given you like over 300 examples of that if you misallocate funds which loudon county did 29 million wasn't a clerical error they

[00:50:29] all still have their licenses but they didn't criticize charlie kirk so they're cool right and also if you engage in behavior that is detrimental to the welfare of children and i don't know how many times we have to tell you how bad our children are suffering and it's ironic to me because you know superintendent braebrand uh former superintendent of fairfax he was part of the problem he was part of the problem y'all part of the problem because your ethics and your oath require you to uphold the constitutional right to be educated of every child

[00:51:08] and protect them. Not Charlie Kirk. He done gone on to glory or wherever he went. So I need you to have that same energy going after individuals that are licensed like myself who misappropriate funds, funnel it to Sands Anderson Law Firm, and then say we need more money. Or like Mr. Brabrandt, school division former school division we have individuals giving hearing officers incentives

[00:51:41] to dismiss our cases i pulled the invoices from fairfax okay and on october 23rd 2020 we had an individual don schaefer thank you for the special education department submit a request for them to receive incentives thank you very much okay don't do that cheryl

[00:52:11] sims don't do that cheryl sims followed by chris scott fleming cheryl sims followed by

[00:52:22] scott fleming cheryl sims followed by scott fleming cheryl sims okay scott fleming scott fleming followed by chris jones good morning members of the board madam superintendent thank

[00:53:00] you for the opportunity to speak this morning it is a great day in virginia isn't it we have a remarkable opportunity as a state to continue to hold high expectations for all of our students as many of you know last year the state was recognized as being number one for education which contributed to our status of being number one for business however it is not all clear sanely over the last four years we have seen remedial or developmental education education that is now called, grow by 23% since 2000. There are more students in remedial or developmental education now than there were in the year 2000. In one year, developmental education rates have

[00:53:39] grown by 12%. This is not the type of data that will encourage or help maintain Virginia's status as the number one state for education. As the, apologies, I am the Executive Director for the State Council of Higher Education for Virginia. I currently live in Mechanicsville. My role as the executive director of the Coordinating Council for Virginia is to support public and private higher education in the Commonwealth. What we are seeing and what I'm hearing from our executive directors, chief executives, and other university administration is that students are leaving public K-12 education unprepared for rigorous post-secondary education. That cascades into their

[00:54:17] post-secondary experience and further into the workforce. Students that participate in developmental education are less likely to complete. They are more likely to stop out with debt and enter the population of students with some college and no degree. And as you know, students with some college and no degree are most likely to have the least positive economic outcomes despite spending time in post-secondary education. So my encouragement to the board is to maintain high expectations.

[00:54:47] As a commonwealth, as our economy, and for our students, we should be focusing on the best outcomes that we can support. Our post-secondary institutions are among the best in the world, and they are telling us that we can do better. And so I encourage the board to maintain and encourage and maintain high standards for the students of Virginia.

[00:55:06] Thank you. Chris Jones, followed by Dan Zacharias. Chris Jones. Dan Zacharias, followed by Patrice Wilson. Thank you, Madam President and members of the board.

[00:55:32] I'm Dan Zacharias. I'm executive director of the Old Dominion Association of Church Schools, and I'm presenting some data to you that I have presented before that I thought this would be a good opportunity to do it again because we have some new board members who have not been able to hear or probably had this data presented to them.

[00:55:55] Our church-run daycares and preschools operate with a religious exemption from child care licensure. With that exemption, despite the exemption, they still come under DOE purview for safety inspections.

[00:56:15] And for many years, we have been criticized without data as being unsafe by default, simply because we're not licensed. And we are working hard to counter that argument with actual data.

[00:56:32] The first sheet that I presented to you comes, it mines through data from the Department of Social Services. They collect data on submitted, suspected cases of child abuse and founded cases of child abuse throughout the Commonwealth, and they aggregate that data very specifically by location, by the type of setting, including licensed child care and religiously exempt child care, and whether the cases were founded or unfounded.

[00:57:03] in a recent three-year period from their fiscal year 21 to 24 in licensed child care settings in Virginia, there were 175 founded cases of child abuse that occurred. 175. In the same three-year period in religiously exempt centers, there were eight. 175 to eight. Also troubling was that from the first of those three years to the third, the number of founded cases in the licensed

[00:57:39] centers doubled from 35 to 70. Now, if you scale that for enrollment, you know, what about the enrollment factor? That's a fair question. You still, with the kindest data we can find, come up with a four to one ratio. Our centers, the children in our centers are at least four times safer, possibly as much as five or six. Now, we're not saying that licensed centers are unsafe. We're just saying that we're safer. And in a sane world, the Department of Ed would come to us and say, what makes the difference? I think that's a question that needs to be asked. Instead,

[00:58:17] we're getting a lot of overreach from licensing inspectors. So thank you for taking time to listen to our concerns and for examining that data. I appreciate your time. Patrice Wilson followed by Freddie Bird. Good morning, Madam Chair Creasy, members of the board. My name is Dr. Patrice Wilson, and I serve as the proud principal of Binsley Elementary School in

[00:58:53] Chesterfield County, Virginia. I am also the immediate past president of the Virginia Association of Elementary School Principals. I'm here today to speak with you regarding the proposed cut scores. Remember, I serve as the proud principal of a nationally title one distinguished elementary school who currently is anticipating a designation of in need of intensive support. First, let me thank you for your commitment to raising expectations for our

[00:59:27] students. We all share the same goal, ensuring that every child in Virginia has access to a rigorous, high-quality education that prepares them for success. We have serious concerns about the process that has led to these specific recommendations. In particular, where is the process or where in the process has the voice of the principal been included? Of the 200 members serving on the committee, how many are current elementary or middle school principals? The very

[01:00:04] leaders responsible for implementing these expectations in real time. Principals are the instructional leaders of their schools, yet we're being asked to guide our staff and students and build trust with families without complete or timely information. We are still adjusting to a brand new performance. And excuse me, this is a passion for me, so I'm a little shaky. We are still adjusting to a brand new performance framework that itself requires refinement. We do not yet

[01:00:42] have full data from the 2025 spring SOL assessments and growth score information has not been released. To raise cut scores mid-year without providing school leaders with the necessary data, preparation, and voice in the process is quite frankly asking us to lead while driving with one arm tied behind our backs.

[01:01:08] On behalf of principals across the Commonwealth, I respectfully urge this board to pause and reconsider the timing and process of these changes. give us the tools, the information, and the seat at the table we need in order to successfully lead our schools through this important work.

[01:01:32] Thank you for your time and for your continued commitment to Virginia students. Thank you. Freddie Byrd, followed by Lawanda Travis. First, giving honor to God and thanking you all for the opportunity to come be before the board this morning.

[01:01:53] I'm coming in concern in reference to my county, King of Wayne County, and the superintendent in that county being given access to do as she pleases with the funds that she has, with the evaluation that has not been done as far as a evaluation of superintendent in the area, and then making decisions without including the community.

[01:02:19] I think it's very necessary that Virginia School Board gets involved with this because this is getting out of hand. We're getting ready to be taxed in an area that we have no decision-making process with this, and then having to afford building another school in an area that is a wetland.

[01:02:45] Children's lives are at stake. I believe what we should be doing is being concerned about the students, their education, and also the welfare of the community when it comes down to taking the children from their homes, busing them for an hour and 30 minutes to one central location.

[01:03:08] There are three schools in the district, and the district superintendent is being paid more than any superintendent in this state. and I'm trying to figure out why. She has the least number of students. She also has teachers that are there, that are underpaid. They are also not being evaluated by a code of conduct or a code of ethics. When I was in the military, I always had to abide by the code of conduct.

[01:03:40] I appreciate if the board would get involved with this so that there'll be some guidelines on how we run our schools. Thank you. Lawanda Travis, followed by Jeremy Bennett.

[01:03:54] Good morning, Madam Chair and Board. Thank you again for allowing us to come out here. Again, I'm here on behalf of King and Queen County's communities concerned citizens. We did have our school board meeting last night, and there were some more concerns that were brought up. And again, I always come to you asking for accountability, transparency, and the safety of our children.

[01:04:26] I was more shaken this week than anything when, unfortunately, we had a bomb threat to the area. There are only three schools in the district, however. Two were closed and one was open. And my concern as a public servant as well as a military member is if you're going to close the district, you close all schools.

[01:04:51] Because if there was a threat to the school, why would you leave one open if there was a bomb threat for somebody to eventually take our children and our teachers out? But safety is a big concern, as well as the equality and the education for these students.

[01:05:09] I'm a product of King and Queen County. I have five children, all who have graduated from either Ivy League or HBCUs that are currently serving in the government and other roles. I have students that I've actually teached and coached from King and Queen County that I'm happy to say one of them left out of here early.

[01:05:32] she didn't recognize me, but she left out here earlier dancing. And then there was the young lady. She's not a student of mine, but she didn't realize who I was for the academy here. And that is what we are looking for all students and as well as adults to be able to do with their life, to show their progression and what they have achieved. And we as the educators, as well as public servants should be able to give that to them in a safe environment, as well as everybody

[01:06:05] afforded that opportunity that our Constitution states an equal and fair education. But if we do not use our democracy to do this, we will lose everything that we have fought for. Thank you.

[01:06:21] Jeremy Bennett, Alyn Parham. Good morning, members of the board. My name is actually pronounced a Lynn Parm and I currently teach AP African-American studies along with world history too and world geography and I serve as a proud member of the Virginia Education Association

[01:06:58] and live in Newport, New Virginia. I'm here today because I believe in high standards and accountability and I know firsthand how clear expectations can motivate students to excel. In my classroom, I don't suddenly change the grading scale after students have already turned in their essence. We set the bar early. We make sure everyone understands what meets the standards look like, for example, providing a rubric, and we provide feedback, feedback that they need to get there. But when the bar moves mid-course, even my hardest working students do lose confidence,

[01:07:37] wondering where the goalposts will keep shifting, no matter how much effort they put in. This week or next marks the release of the first school-by-school standards under a brand new performance and support framework. House Bill 1957 will compress all SOL testing into a two-week window, tie 10% of course grades for 7 through 12 to SOL results, and transition to a 100-point scoring scale. Through year growth, assessments delayed for two years are set to return, and there is talk

[01:08:13] of redesigning the entire assessment system, introducing performance tasks and project-based measures in the next state budget cycle. Layering major cut score increases on top of all of this will create a cascade of moving parts that teachers, students, and parents simply cannot track or trust. Myself, along with numerous co-workers in all fields and levels in public education are concerned, it seems like the board hasn't given anyone, teachers, students, or parents

[01:08:46] time to fully grasp and understand this deeply. Many feel that this is unfair, as our students are continuously trying to reach the top of the mountain that just keeps on growing. This would only cause additional stress on students, especially our students who do struggle with mental health.

[01:09:04] We all want honest, rigorous measures of student learning. However, teachers, superintendents, and parents have been asking the board repeatedly to model the real-world impact of higher cut scores. We still don't know what would happen to graduation rates in a state where passing certain tests is tied to earning a diploma. Other states have seen significant increases in failure rates when

increasing their cut scores, leading to drops in graduation. We don't know how many schools will suddenly appear off track or needs intensive support when nearly half of

[01:09:41] elementary and middle schools. Thank you so much. I thank you for your time and your dedication to strengthening our policy. Thank you. Todd Truitt followed by Rodney Jordan. Good morning, Superintendent Gullickson and board members. My name is Todd Truitt and I'm a parent of two public school students in Arlington. I'm speaking today in strong support of raising the cut scores. Virginia's cut scores are the lowest in the nation, and thankfully calls to raise them

[01:10:18] are not from just parents in the Commonwealth, but also big left-leaning national names in education, such as the Collaborative for Student Success, Denise Fort, head of the leading education civil rights group, the Education Trust, and President Obama's former Secretary of Education, Arne Duncan, a former Arlington Public School parent. Virginia has been talking about doing this for over three years now. You've had countless hearings, consulted with numerous leading national experts, had voluminous amounts of meetings with Virginia school principals,

[01:10:53] superintendents, business leaders, parents, and community members. And now you'll be doing another month-long feedback session on the phase-in period. To say this process has been exhaustive is putting it lightly. Although I'm disappointed these cut score changes are not happening immediately, I support a four to five year phase in period. Virginia will likely be doing something similar with much needed SOL testing reforms. Senator Schuyler Van Balkenburg in the last legislative session, speaking in support of his SOL testing reform bill, talked about the need there for a similar phase in period, stating, quote, when we move fast,

[01:11:32] we break things, end quote, in testing. It's likely those SOL testing reforms will phase in at the same time as these cut score changes completely phase in. Most importantly, raising the cut scores to NAEP Proficient will be a significant improvement for notifying parents as to whether their children are on the path to college. NAEP Proficient has been generally shown to mean a child is college ready. If a child is not hitting that metric, many parents will want to talk to their teachers to see how they can help their children. With the current cut scores,

[01:12:04] Parents often have no idea. Virginia parents deserve the same actionable information about their children's academic performance on SOLs as parents in Maryland, Massachusetts, Colorado, and numerous other states. For instance, for the 2024 NAEP math, Virginia had a slightly higher percentage of kids performing proficient than Maryland, but the state standardized test results tell a completely different story.

[01:12:30] For the 24-25 school year, Maryland's statewide proficient rate on its math standardized test was 26.5%, while Virginia's rate on its math SOL was 72%. Let's make it happen for Virginia families and communities. Thank you.

[01:12:50] Rodney Jordan, followed by Rachel O'Brien. Good morning, President Creasy, Vice President Anson, members of the Virginia Board of Education and Superintendent Guggson.

[01:13:10] My name is Rodney Jordan, and I'm here representing the Virginia School Boards Association, VSBA, to provide comments on the proposed 2025-2026 proficiency cut scores. VSBA members of the school board share with you the goal of setting high expectations for students while providing the support and resources to undergird every learner to meet those expectations.

[01:13:31] Local school boards, in representing the vision and values of their communities, collaborate with their division superintendents to set meaningful student achievement goals, informed by data and driven by quality instruction. Previously, we joined with others requesting that extensive modeling of student performance impacts, as well as transparency around the impact of the new cut scores on state budget funding streams, tied to SOL outcomes, graduation rates, and the new performance and support framework.

[01:14:02] On behalf of our school board members, we request again a division-by-division impact modeling of the proposed higher cut scores be provided before your final decision and vote. In our shared goal with the board to grow continuously our students' performance towards career, college, and life readiness to compete nationally and around the globe, BSBA remains dedicated to support excellent student outcomes for each and every public school student.

[01:14:32] Critical to achieving that goal is communicating with clarity and transparency the current reality for students and the instruction, resources, and supports necessary to ensure student success.

[01:14:45] In conclusion, we ask again that you complete and share with school divisions an impact analysis of the proposed cut scores prior to adoption so that collectively we may implement a school performance framework whereby parents, students, teachers, and members of the community understand how our public education system is performing and the resources needed and invested to drive excellence in our public schools today and in the future.

[01:15:14] Thank you. Rachel O'Brien, followed by Michaela Christensen.

[01:15:29] Madam Chair, members of the board, Superintendent Gullitson. My name is Rachel O'Brien, and I'm the Director of Talent and Workforce Initiatives at the Virginia Economic Development Partnership. I reside here in Richmond, Virginia. VEDP understands the importance of the workforce for economic development.

[01:15:48] Virginia's greatest asset is its people, and we are committed to positioning the Commonwealth as America's top state for talent, as a core goal of Virginia's economic development strategy. To accomplish this goal, we need to attract and retain talent, align education to employer needs, including and especially the development of the right skills and knowledge, and reduce barriers to employment, including workplace readiness. This work should start with early childhood education and continue through the K-12 system, providing clear guideposts that support long-term workforce development. A strong education system lays the foundation for a strong economy.

[01:16:28] That's why CNBC's top state for business ranking include K-12 education as a key metric. Virginia's number one ranking in education is a selling point when recruiting businesses to the Commonwealth and encouraging existing business to expand here. Employers want to know that Virginia can deliver the skilled workforce they need today and in the future. The Virginia Office of Education Economics, a division of the EDP, exemplifies the Commonwealth's commitment to aligning education with employer needs. VOE data and analyses help identify the degrees, credentials,

[01:17:04] and skills that students need to successfully transition from the classroom to the workplace. According to VOE's analysis of job postings data, communication and problem solving are among the most sought-after skills by employers. These competencies, alongside others critical to workplace success are taught across subject areas and throughout a student's educational experience beginning in kindergarten.

What students learn during primary and secondary school is fundamental to their future employability. Each stage of education lays the groundwork for the next,

[01:17:41] allowing students to master higher level skills over time and preparing them for a successful transition to career or college upon high school graduation. Position Virginia as a top state for talent, the Commonwealth must cultivate talent starting in elementary school and continuing through middle school and high school. A robust, future-ready K-12 system is essential to prepare today's students for the jobs of tomorrow. This is vital for individual opportunity and it is a strategic imperative for Virginia's economic growth and competitiveness. Thank you. Thank you.

[01:18:20] Mikaela Christensen followed by Yanis Rookwood-Jackson.

[01:18:38] - President Crecy and members of the Virginia Board of Education and Superintendent Gullickson. My name is Mikaela Christensen. I serve as the coordinator for dual enrollment with the Virginia Community College system and I currently live in Prince George. VCCS partners with school divisions statewide to provide more than 55,000 high school students with dual enrollment across the Commonwealth.

[01:18:58] In concert with the Virginia Department of Education, we have successfully implemented most recent college and career-ready legislation to bring dual enrollment to even more high school students across the Commonwealth at no cost to them or their families. BCCS is very committed to this partnership as we work to collectively ensure that all of our high school students have either secured employment, enlisted in the armed forces, or identified their educational path that has included earning college credits prior to their graduation. We come before you today in support of the work that BDOE is currently doing to build trust between schools, parents, and

[01:19:33] students. Thank you for the opportunity to speak before you this morning. Thank you. Yanis Rookwood Johnson, followed by Amy Beaumont. Hi, good morning, Madam Chair and members of the board. My name is Yanis Rookwood Jackson, and I am the mother of two children with disabilities, Zurich Jackson, Jr., a ninth grader, and Amina Jackson, a seventh grader. I stand before you today because House bill 2606 carries devastating risks for families like mine. It allows hearing officers to dismiss complaints they label as repetitive invictations. On paper, this sounds like a safeguard. However,

[01:20:11] in practice, it's risk closing the courthouse doors on families fighting for their children's education. Allow me to share what this means in real life, which is my life currently. In 2023, Colonial Heights Public Schools admitted that they could not educate my son, Zarek. Within five months after advocacy, he was placed at North Star Academy by Colonial Heights Public School expense under private day placement with transportation provided to and from. He went from straight S due to Colonial Heights Public School's actions that when he left to go to North Star Academy, he is now a straight A scholar student with an advanced diploma on track to pursue a triple

[01:20:51] major in college, robotics, coding, drones, and electrical engineering. Two weeks into his ninth grade high school year with North Star Academy, tragedy struck. How? Well, I asked a simple question in reference to changing his schedule. And I wanted to know about an investigation into a teacher misconduct from the prior year that was never divulged to me. He was made to stand up in front of class, in front of his classmates and peers for a solid 10 minutes because he dozed off in class. So please tell me, I know there's been other people that have dozed off in class

[01:21:27] before. However, instead of the meeting of professional minds or staff and faculty, there was genuinely no interest in my son's or daughter's educational growth. Okay, retaliation followed very swiftly. Okay, the HB 2606 bill would label me repetitive for filing complaints to protect him when in truth I am fighting for his future, his advanced diploma, and his college career.

[01:21:52] My daughter, a seventh grader, is just as troubling. She has a six-year reading gap, a seventh grader reading on the first grade level. And you'd like to know how is this possible? A due process hearing was held with Colonial Heights Public Schools Division, where they were ordered to provide her with Orton-Gillingham certified instructors. Yet, the order was never carried out. Her IEP is still in stay-put status.

[01:22:15] When I raised these concerns on how we can come together, it was, I got immediate pushback. Yes, this law expires in 2027, but in those two years, children's like mine's irreplaceable time. Zurich is already missing weeks of instruction. Amin is still waiting for services this division was ordered to provide.

[01:22:34] HB 2602 could give hearing officers the power to call my persistence dictatious when it's simply a mother's fight for her children's rights under IDEA and Section 504.

[01:22:45] I ask the board. Thank you very much. This is not hypothetical, but please, we must come together to do something about this. Thank you for your time. Thank you. Amy Beaumont, followed by Philip Abouzaki. Good morning. President Creasy, Vice President Hanson, board members, and Superintendent Collinson. My name is Amy Beaumont, and I'm a parent in Arlington County, where I've served on ATS's math advisory committee for 12 years. I speak today in support of the proposed changes to the SOL cut scores.

[01:23:23] Together with the prior release of more rigorous math and reading standards and a more transparent accountability framework, these proposed changes and the cut scores will ensure that Virginia better prepares our students to succeed in any life pathway that she is. The foremost responsibility of Virginia schools is to graduate students who are both literate and numerate.

[01:23:45] To do that, we have to set high expectations and transparently report student progress to families. Regrettably, Virginia is not doing that. Virginia has the unfortunate distinction of having the lowest cut scores on its fourth-grade reading and math standardized exams of any state in the nation and is tied to the lowest eighth-grade reading.

[01:24:06] Low cut scores of inflated pass rates give parents a false sense about how well their child is doing. Too often, parents may not realize their child is missing foundational skills until Florida down the road when they struggle in highly of a process. For example, many kids who struggle in algebra are not falling down on algebra itself, but rather are suffering from a lack of fat fluency that exceeds their ability to factor.

[01:24:32] It is difficult to bank up foundational gaps at that late stage. The better approach is to provide an honest accounting to families on an ongoing basis of their children's strengths and weaknesses. That is what the proposed increase in best wars will do. Armed with this knowledge, families can work with schools but remedy gaps much sooner, which will set students up for success in future courses and allow them to emerge from high school ready for a career in life.

[01:25:00] I had the privilege of participating in the June CUTTS World Committee meetings for math, and I want to commend the Department of Education for the thorough and thoughtful work that has gone into developing these new CUTTS schools. I was particularly impressed by the rigor of the value of the process, the depth of knowledge shared by veteran teachers and administrators, and the valuable insights offered by community members.

[01:25:23] This well-managed and robust process gives confidence that the proposed cut scores will enhance the engineering education. Thank you. Good morning, President Creasy, members of the board. My name is Phil Babazaki. I'm a resident of Ben Lothian.

[01:25:46] I spent the last 20 years in the plumbing and pipe pit industry within the Commonwealth. People think about plumbing. They often picture a wrench and a leaking pipe. The reality today couldn't be further from that. Modern plumbing and pipefitter require precision, advanced problem solving, and strong math skills. Pipes we install are part of massive, complex systems in hospitals, universities, high-tech buildings. Our teams utilize 3D modeling software, read technical blueprints, and make calculations that require algebra, geometry, and trigonometry. That's why I'm here to support raising proficiency expectations for our students. Success of our

[01:26:22] industries like mine depend on graduates who are ready to step in apprenticeships, technical training programs with a solid foundation in math and critical thinking. Right now, too many students are graduating without the skills they need to succeed. We hire promising young people who are motivated and hardworking, but they struggle with the math needed to do the job. That shows that slows down their progress, creates frustration, and ultimately limits their earning potential.

[01:26:50] When we raise expectations, we send a message to students, families, and schools. We believe in our kids and know they are capable of more. High standards are about preparing young people for real-world success. The construction industry is changing fast with billions of dollars in infrastructure investments.

[01:27:10] Our state has a once-in-a-generation opportunity to grow its workforce and economy. But if we don't have graduates who can meet the technical demands of today's jobs, we'll lose that opportunity, and those jobs will go elsewhere. I urge you to raise proficiency cut scores and hold our education system to the same high standards we expect in the workplace.

[01:27:28] Our students and our industries deserve nothing less. Thank you for your time and the work you do with our kids and the help of our state's future. Thank you. At this time, are there any other persons present who wish to speak?

[01:27:45] Please make sure that when you come to the microphone, you let us know your name and your affiliation where you live in Virginia. Good morning, Board.

[01:28:05] first giving honors to my lord and savior jesus christ to y'all everybody assembled here today my name is minister sheryl sims and i was given garnership of my grandsons connor and cory gunn we live out you i live out in goochland they were entitled to faith under federal law but goochland county public school never gave it to them their iep was ignored five threat assessments were disregarded doctors orders residential play doctor order residential placement and private placement for the other. But the school and its partners twisted those facts into accusations

[01:28:44] against me. Because fate was denied, my grandsons were taken from me unlawfully through judicial misconduct. Custody was lost, not because of neglect. It was lost because the system retaliated against me as I demanded service for my grandsons and I would not stop advocating. I stand here to declare this with boldness. The Most High sent me to have a conversation with you. He says when schools deny children their lawful rights, they are not just breaking statues, they are breaking

[01:29:18] families. And if you're a person that believes in God and you read the Bible, it says if you offend one of God's little ones, you may as well tie a millstone around your neck and drown yourself in this seat. I urge the Virginia Department of Education hold Goochland County Public Schools accountable. Ensure no more children are robbed of faith, especially children with disabilities and are traumatized. My grandchildren witnessed their mother's murder and was abused. We shouldn't be going through this. I'm still fighting. You will not stop me. Goochland County will not stop me.

[01:29:54] Powhatan County will not stop me. Henrico County will not stop me. Spotsylvania will not stop me because the most high sent me as an ambassador to advocate for my grandkids. I love them with everything I got. I got 13 of them. And guess what? I advocate for all 13. And I advocate for anybody else, child, that needs me too. I urge the Virginia Department of Education, hold Goochland accountable. Please do the right thing. And House Bill 2606, abolish it. It's going to destroy disabled children. And if that sits right with you, I don't see how you sleep at

[01:30:32] night. Thank you. Is there anybody else who wishes to speak during the public comment period? If not, I'm going to close the public comment period and we will move on to the next section of our agenda. Okay. So we're moving on to our consent agenda. Is there a motion to waive first review and approve the items on the consent agenda today? So moved. Second. Any discussion on this

[01:31:05] item? Dr. Ackerman. Mr. Green. Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Mr. Hanson. Aye. Ms. McPherson. Aye. Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Ms. Ashton. Aye. Mr. Monk. Aye. And chair votes aye. Okay. We are moving on to item C. Ms. Booker Dwyer. That's you, I guess. But I just want to say a couple of things before we take this item up. Obviously, today we have the opportunity to take a very crucial step

[01:31:47] toward supporting the future of our students and for the support of future students coming into schools in the Commonwealth. The approval of cut scores that align our expectations of proficiency with the nation. This is not just a technical adjustment. It is a commitment to ensuring every student is truly prepared to experience success in college, career, and military pathways and life beyond the four walls of our school buildings. As a board, we have prioritized setting and helping every learner meet high expectations. We have raised expectations by revising standards of

[01:32:27] learning in mathematics in 2023 and in English in 2024. To measure whether students meet these higher expectations, SOL assessments and test questions in both mathematics and English were fully revised to align to the more rigorous academic standards. Our revised SOL assessments in reading and mathematics require higher order thinking and the integration of multiple skills.

[01:32:56] However, our current cut scores measure proficiency levels for mastery of 2016 mathematics and 2017 English standards. We're measuring today's proficiency expectations using outdated benchmarks. Approving new cut scores are necessary to reflect proficiency expectations for mastery of our more rigorous 2023 mathematics and 2024 English standards. Higher expectations must be matched with increased support. Yesterday we heard how the department is stepping up to strengthen support

[01:33:35] to superintendents, principals, assistant principals, teachers, families through flexible funding models, regional math and literacy networks, and communication toolkits. Raising expectations is good for our students and good for Virginia. It ensures that every graduate is equipped with the skills and knowledge needed to thrive after graduation, including the critical thinking and problem-solving skills to compete and succeed in the real world, many of the things

[01:34:06] that we heard through our public comments today. So, Ms. Booker Dwyer, would you like to take this over from here. I am happy to take this over. And I just, I want to begin by expressing my deep gratitude to everyone who provided public comments, to all the parents, the teachers, the business leaders, the superintendents, principals, who took time to express their support or their concerns with the revised cut scores. I want you to know that we hear you,

[01:34:46] We listen to you. And there's one thing, there was a common theme that came up as I was listening and reading all of the items that were submitted. It is super clear that we all share a commitment to wanting to do what's best for our kids, for preparing them for college, careers, and military pathways, and to ensure that the Virginia diploma means something. We are all clear on that.

[01:35:16] Where I am hearing that there is concern is this balance between raising expectations and the support provided that will get there. Yesterday, we shared our revised approach to supporting school divisions and schools.

[01:35:42] We emphasize that it is not the job of a single office in a state department of education. it is the job of the entire agency. And we want to ensure and we want to assure to all of our divisions and school system leaders that you have the support of the entire agency. And this comes down to the funding. We talked about how we're looking at the flexible funding models. We know that it takes time to improve schools. And so we want to limit, we want to take that cap off that

[01:36:18] nine-month grant cycle because by the time you submit the application, then it's time to submit the mid-year report. You do the mid-year report and the final report is due. So we understand that and we want to expand the timeline that you have to spend those funds. We talked about the $35 million that's going to be available to support literacy, math, to support regionalizing our support to you. We heard, and we have a strategy for supporting principals. You recognize that may

[01:36:51] have been a gap in the past, but that will be a gap no longer. And so we are committed to supporting you to reach those higher expectations. We know that time is needed. This is why we proposed a multi-year phased-in approach. But we have to keep moving while we're setting these high expectations. Because if we propose this phased-in approach and we say, okay, but we're not going to implement, we're not going to hold divisions accountable for these cut scores until 2029,

[01:37:30] well, how fast do you think people will move? How much do you think we will pivot what we're doing if the goalpost is set in 2029? Every year, we have to make incremental progress toward the goals. That is just common in instruction.

[01:37:48] Teachers know that when you get your class, a classroom of students, and you see where they started, you are setting benchmarks for their growth so that by the end of the year, they're not ending where they started. And we applied that same model to this multi-year phased-in approach.

[01:38:06] We do not want to end where we started. We followed research-based practices. it was a valid and reliable process that was implemented. You had Mr. Ellis go through that in detail.

[01:38:26] I also wanna speak to 'cause we wanna ensure that we hear the voice and we're including all stakeholders. And so I want Mr. Ellis to speak specifically to the public comment about principles not being included in the standard setting process.

[01:38:42] And Mr. Ellis, I'll call you up to discuss that. - Good morning, everyone. So to address the topic of principals being engaged in the standard setting process, the application that was posted for all Virginia educators was just that.

[01:38:59] It was available for all Virginia educators. There weren't any limits on whether it could be a division superintendent or any teacher in a school building anywhere. So any application that came in was reviewed on the merits of that application, and that's how the selection process occurred.

[01:39:19] Historically, principals haven't been a part, at least not in significant numbers in past standard settings. Oftentimes, those standard settings happened in the fall of the year during the school year, a time where principals may not have wanted to be out of the building. However, with that said, we do have a significant number of our participants do come from central office, whether it's content specialists, instructional specialists.

[01:39:44] And at the building level, it's not just teachers. it's also the instructional coaches at the building level. So in the scope of all of our educator participants, it's not only teachers. And I don't say that demeaning to the teachers either. But it's not only classroom teachers. It's also individuals from central office and other educators within the building. So Mr. Ellis, what you're saying to us is that there was nothing that would have prevented principals from being a part of this process? Correct. The application was open to everyone. And there would have been nothing to prevent a superintendent or

[01:40:22] an assistant superintendent or anyone who is an educator in Virginia from being a part of the process? That is correct. Thank you. I also want to speak to impact data. Yesterday, we presented the statewide impact data in slides 12 and 13 of that proficiency cut score presentation. One of the things and we listen to what superintendents have to say. And in going around and meeting with superintendents and they've requested from us for their accountability data, we want to see it first

[01:41:01] before you share it publicly. And so that's exactly what we're going to, so we want to follow that model. We have impact data by divisions and we're going around the month of October to each division to share that impact data with them, to talk through strategies on the support that's needed.

[01:41:21] So that's why we're coming back to the board in October for approval of the phase-in model because we can make tweaks. We want to make sure we're doing what's right for the school divisions and honoring requests that they have made. And so if the request was made, do not share our data before we have had a chance to see it.

[01:41:43] We will honor that request. And you saw that yesterday when Mr. Jennings presented the timeline for the accountability data. We heard loud and clear that superintendents wanted more time to review their data. So we set the public release date of October 7th so that they could take time and engage and see their data.

[01:42:04] We want to do the same thing with these impact scores. We want to ensure that they have time to see it, to process it, and that we can collaboratively plan together. And so we are honoring what we heard. I have also, in reading the comments, there's concern over graduation.

[01:42:26] There's concern over accountability. So I'm going to call Mr. Jennings up to address those points. Good morning, everyone. Thank you, Deputy Superintendent Booker Dwyer. As I shared yesterday, graduation is a very complex issue, and that is because we provide so many pathways to ensure students have opportunities to graduate.

[01:42:48] It's not as simple as saying, you know, raise the cut scores, and now a child can't graduate. They failed. They're reading SOL. We can share with you how we have locally verified credits to give students opportunities. We have what's called a term graduate where students are taking a test version to ensure they have multiple attempts, and we use a proficiency cut score, the former proficiency cut scores.

[01:43:08] We talk about our students with special needs, how they have credit accommodations. These are just a few of the ways that we ensure that both schools, divisions, the state's provided resources to help students graduate on time and providing actually additional time to help them be successful as well. With this approach, and again, you've heard from the stakeholders, that's why we're proposing to you a phased-in approach. We hear the concerns, especially out of our high schoolers and the verified credit piece for reading and mathematics, and so we're bringing to you this proposal to have phased-in. We'll be back in October after engaging with stakeholders, as Deputy Superintendent Booker Dwyer just said, to talk

[01:43:44] around the accountability side. The accountability system is very much predicated on the individual child. And we heard great public comment earlier around growth. We want to see students succeed. We want to see a true indication of where they are. We want true measurement of their performance. We want to see them grow in that. We want to see students accelerate. And so we have a framework that gives students opportunities to do that. Students are recognized and awarded when they accelerate. And so we want to continue to honor that. And so as you look at an accountability system that is weighted and brings in all these factors, we want to engage with stakeholders to look and see with the moving pieces, how they're affected. And so again, I'm excited to reach out

[01:44:22] to the divisions and schools and bring back to you in a few weeks, sort of our findings and what we propose in the accountability system. But to say again, it's not a simple answer and it shouldn't be because we are talking about, you know, looking at children's growth. We're looking at how you're measuring a school, the impact on teachers and impact on instruction. And so again, we're excited to engage with stakeholders on that. Dr. Ackerman? Mr. Jennings, if I may, because just in case anybody missed it yesterday, I've heard people are concerned about two major things, and that's

[01:44:58] accreditation and verified credits. Can you address again the issue of accreditation with the proficiency cut scores for folks who may have missed that yesterday? Excellent. Yeah. So again, the system is now bifurcated in the state, the nation, actually. Virginia was one of the last states to bifurcate their system and use the word accreditation to mean both accountability and truly what the word accreditation means, inputs. You think of institutions being accredited.

[01:45:24] So no school, we can say this definitively, no school because of a change in cut scores would lose accreditation status. I know how in Virginia that word's been used, but that does not affect your accreditation status at all. When we talk about graduation requirements, we are definitively saying and asking the board to support that for the graduating class of 2026, they would use the current proficiency cut scores are 400. So, you know, for those parents, the concerns out there, we know there's quite a bit of misinformation for the graduating class of 2026. There's no change in that. Again, there's many nuances I could go into around test administration and other pathways

[01:46:00] that students have. Happy to share that with you. We have tons of technical guides and we welcome people and we'll be on the road talking with that. And what I really want to stress is those opportunities. This is not meant to penalize students. We see how graduation impacts a family, impacts a child, impacts the career, and impacts the school, the accountability system. That's not what this is intended to do at all. We know the theme of when you raise standards, how it improves everyone and the outcomes there. But again, to be very clear, graduation rates or raising the cut scores will have no impact on the accreditation status.

[01:46:35] Thank you. We are looking forward to continuing to engage with our stakeholders. We are not done yet, and we don't plan to be done anytime soon.

[01:46:53] This is going to be ongoing. Our support is going to be ongoing. Funding streams are going to be ongoing. We hope the General Assembly will keep it coming, because we want to do what's best for our kids. And I think we're all committed to that.

[01:47:09] And I'll open the floor for any questions. Any questions for Ms. Booker Dwyer? Okay. With that, what I'd like to remind everyone of is that the final policy implementation plan, including the multi-year phased-in approach of no less than four years and accommodations for current high school students, will be presented for final action at the October 24 business meeting.

[01:47:40] You've heard staff talking about the roadshow they are getting ready to take on to seek additional input. But today, I'm asking for a motion to approve the superintendent's recommended cut scores that are on the boilerplate, page 3. We've all seen these before. These were under first review last month.

[01:48:01] So again, I'm asking for a motion to approve the superintendent's recommendation of cut scores for reading and mathematics SOL tests throughout the month of October. The department, again, is going to continue to do those meetings with stakeholders. But today is, I'm asking for that motion to approve the cut scores for reading and mathematics SOL tests.

[01:48:23] So second. Any discussion here? Dr. Northern. So, I'm going to try to keep it brief, but we've been at this for so long, I just feel the need to, like, reappraise where we are. Somebody said we've been at it three years, and that's exactly right. I mean, ever since I've been on the board, like, we've been at this thing.

[01:48:44] I just want to remind folks of a couple things. Virginia lost ground, more ground in achievement than any other state. Like, we can't keep forgetting that. From 2019 to 2022, our state, the Commonwealth of Virginia, lost more achievement growth than any other state in the country.

[01:49:03] So that's really bad news. Number two, when you look at the proficiency cut scores in Virginia, the federal department puts out a report, we've all seen it before, and they map the proficiency cut scores against NAEP, which yes, means college ready. And once again, Virginia is the absolute lowest scoring state in terms of proficiency cut score than any other state in the country. So we have two very dubious quote honors hanging around our neck, honestly, and it's embarrassing and it's sad. I think the

[01:49:39] One anecdote I'll share, and I may have shared this before, my godchild moved from Maryland where they take the PARC test, which is not called PARC anymore, but it is shown to be one of the most rigorous tests in the country, right?

[01:49:54] And then they moved to Virginia. And my godchild called me and said, you know, Aunt Amber, that SOL test was a joke. He's like, I cannot believe how much easier it was than the Maryland test I took.

[01:50:10] Like, that was just such an aha moment that a 16-year-old teenager would call me up to tell me that the SOL test was a joke. His mom, my best friend, ended up moving him out into a private, you know, college, like a private, you know, preparatory college.

[01:50:28] How many parents can afford to move their kid to a college prep college, I mean, preparatory school, when their kid comes home and says something like that? Very few. So I think, you know, what I want to say is that this is not about our teachers are terrible. Our kids can't do it.

[01:50:44] It's about that we expect so little of them. We expect so little of them. And so I think this is all about like we will, if we set the bar, they will rise. We've seen it in other states who've done this. The phased in approach makes sense.

[01:50:59] I mean, from the very beginning, I was sort of like, I was sort of out on a limb because many folks on this board weren't in for a phased in approach. I was saying it years ago, because I didn't think that it was fair, honestly, just to bump, because we got such a wide gap to get us there, that I did think it was unfair. And I'm a former teacher. So I'm like, okay, that's a lot. And besides that, we need to hold ourselves accountable as a board and a state agency. I just really feel like by us saying, like, we are going to support you. We're going to come shoulder to shoulder. We're going to do this together. This state Education Agency has never been in the position of providing as much supports and help to districts

[01:51:38] as they are now. I mean, honestly, I work with states all across the country. Like, only state departments that are stepping up and doing what we're getting ready to do see results. And we've been reticent to do it. But we have to do it because we know how poorly we're performing. So I'll just say that I think that for a year, and I know we're going to get more input and yada yada. Personally, I would have been happy with a three-year. I'm certainly not happy with an eight-year. But hey, four-year, okay, we see where we got to go. The teachers understand where they've got to go. And I think that it makes some sense. Again, it's going to give us time to work hand-in-hand. It's going to give us time to look at our support system,

[01:52:17] what's working, what's not working. And it's going to allow us to work together as a team. I'll say what Mr. Jennings said again. It's not punitive. It's not A through F. What do you get in the last category of needing more improvement? You get more help and more support. Like, oh, wow that's just you know like we built it so it was actually supportive we put it in the name so i just want to say again that we can do this together i feel like the division division thing we've already heard the divisions didn't want us publicly to come out and say where they were so we're actually doing in a way that they want us to do it let's do it like let's meet with you one-on-one let's discuss hey here's where you need to move the needle here's what here's what

[01:52:54] the data are showing and why this is coming out like it is here the supports we're going to provide you like that's all like they want to have that as a private conversation and i respect that before we slap it in the paper okay so um i i think that that all makes sense and i just want to close with saying like we can do this together we're not out to get you we're out to actually um do the biggest most important thing that we can do as a society which is invest in education for children it's to um you know reduce social inequality that's what we're talking about reducing social inequality we're talking about earnings potential for our kids we're talking

[01:53:32] about driving economic growth we're talking about where they can actually live happy productive lives because they are educated and so i'll get off my soapbox um but honestly um that's what i wanted to Mr. Hanson?

[01:53:48] Thank you, President. I think that was said, and I don't know what I was going to say, but I just think that we're taking, it's increasing with us, and we've been at this for almost three and a half years, and it's the seamless hook, and this has not been a class in the panel process

[01:54:21] so really goes into credible solicitors so um feedback across the college and across the years and so you know so this guy from the superintendent of her team just uh continue this and back to this and i think uh going on coming to i

[01:54:56] trying to do something to change our national system and led by the comment that you know we're trying to damn the software with low expectations and i think that is exactly what commonwealths have faced in the prior 12 years with the gun down and the continual drop-in of expectations and so i was really interested in so that three distinctions in terms of the

[01:55:29] most honesty gap and that was cusco and also the business throughout the program of tomberg and things the same way and expecting different results there was not good interest and so i I really am very pleased as well as we listen and get input is going to make the most sense

[01:56:05] to make sure that we're accommodating with school students in particular in the process but really most of the accommodations need to be for the kids and for the system and so i hope that's where we wind up and also a lot of this going forward is going to be really leading to align our resources to meet the needs of what's going to be coming out of this system and i i really would encourage people to go back and look at the georgetown university

[01:56:39] lab for education finance presentation that the board received back in july from margarita rosa but from the last 10 years we actually had a drop in students and the commonwealth from 1.26 million to 1.2 million and within that we actually had an increase in our special ed enrollment by about 25 000 students but at the same time um it's great our math scores in fourth grade reading scores

[01:57:15] dropped 10 percent while at the same time our spending has gone at 47 percent and even taken into account for inflation um it was just we have been spending more and even in these last three years with the unprecedented investments and um teacher pay and high dosage tutoring some of the other initiatives that have been passed and proposed by the governor and the general assembly resources are there it is going to be just incredibly important for us to align

[01:57:50] the resources to meet the needs so that um you know we have this comprehensive system of support that helps us move the needle and helps us to get back on track to where we are shining so here on the hill for our country to be looking to um that is top in the nation instead of where we've been and so i just very want to um commend all of the work that's got us to this point and again i just this is going to be an ongoing process with um

[01:58:26] leaders across the commonwealth and with parents and students but just again encourage everyone involved in this process going forward to keep their eye on the students and what is best for them to really help them and i appreciate uh scott's comments earlier to have them prepared for their future academic and component opportunities that are before them and so this uh president thank you for letting me have a minute here but just uh thank you again for your leadership and

[01:59:01] good industry thank you dr ackerman um yes thank you and i i'm one of the newbies to the board but i want to thank those who've been around for those three years and have really worked hard to put together um a very thorough reliable and fair assessment of where we need to go next and so i'm appreciative of that i do feel like though i was brought to the board to be somewhat of the voice for students with special needs and and uh you know i've heard from some of my my colleagues and special educators out there in the state of virginia mostly around the issue of verified credits um and i i'm really really pleased to see that uh the superintendent and the board has

[01:59:40] really taken some of those thoughts to heart but one thing i do want to caution people is we can't go back i was teach i've been a teacher long enough to remember where most of our students with special needs were exempted from testing and there were really we really communicated to them we have no expectations for you and so when we start looking at populations separate from the rest of the population that is a message that gets sent our expectations for you are lower and so i'm really proud that we have been careful about how this will impact of course graduation while always also maintaining the things that are already in place such as accommodations

[02:00:17] for students with special needs other ways of getting verified credits and so things will be business as usual for a population that is very important to me and as much of been my background i'm also very pleased that in this new format of testing we're going to have this great data for parents and again when you speak for families of kids with special needs having that information and understanding how your student is doing in a class but may not be college bound is is been a

[02:00:52] hard thing in our field for many years how do we communicate what these test scores mean how do we communicate when you have an alternative assessment what does that alternative assessment mean for students with special needs and of course for those parents and families so i'm really pleased that i think the voice of those subgroups have been considered and um the finalizing of these plans uh the parent communication and then whether or not we do four or five years so i appreciate the comments i've gotten from my fellow special educators out there the comments we heard today

[02:01:29] i've never heard anyone express that we don't need to raise the bar actually never heard it not once from anybody in the public everybody seems to be in agreement we need to raise the bar it's always been questions around the impact and i think this superintendent's office and her team is ready for that so thank you thank you everybody miss mcpherson well i was thinking this morning about the fact that everybody that sits on the board has been educated and we are members that have been granted the public trust as it relates to education. We got here because there were good

[02:02:08] teachers that poured into us and we were products of good schools and we didn't come from a time period where kids couldn't read or write or do math. It would be very negligent of us to leave behind other people when we've been granted such gifts. So as it stands now, the job for us is to make sure that we communicate to the field that based upon the data, the house is on fire. There

[02:02:45] has to be a sense of urgency that we have to do something about education in Virginia. That means that whatever we roll out, every teacher's position should be, I must rise to the occasion as quickly as I possibly can. Every superintendent should make sure that the school system, the position would be, we will rise to the occasion to change what is happening here.

[02:03:13] That's what we expect. Our role is to give you all the resources that the General Assembly puts and trust to us to pour out to you. I will be looking closely at the data for schools that are

underperforming, attempting to figure out why, asking the staff, drill down, drill down, tell us why, what's going on at that particular school. That's our role, and to come out and to provide the support and the funding to you. Well, the new approaches for workforce development is not only going to be high demand jobs. We're looking for high tech jobs. We're looking for our kids to be

[02:03:51] the best of the best and for us to give them everything. We're looking for public support, local community support. We're looking for our HBCUs to partner with. We're looking for our local community colleges to partner. Every organization, every industry, it's everybody's job to pour into the students of the future because it reflects on all of us. As we move into the celebration of 250 years of this country and Virginia being a large part of that, the worst thing in the world would be for people around the nation and say, but they can't educate their students. I refuse to be a part

[02:04:28] of that. And so I want to commend the staff, the Secretary Gullickson, the whole team for all the work you've done and just say, everybody, let's look towards a brighter future and it starts now. When it comes to the phasing approach, we recognize that we'll have to do some phasing in, But we can't phase in over a lifetime.

[02:04:48] Eight years, a student from first grade to eighth grade, and at the end of that, we would say they still can't read, write, and do basic math. That is unacceptable. So when we talk about phase in, it has to be with increments showing improved success over whatever period of time that the board elects.

[02:05:07] That's where we're headed. And I think that has to be the focus of every single person. Mr. Green? Well, I echo, first I want to say I echo all of the comments made by my colleagues here on the board.

[02:05:22] I want to say that I'm encouraged by the leadership and the hard work of Superintendent Gullickson, Deputy Superintendent Booker Dwyer, Assistant Superintendents Ellis, Ann Jennings, all that they have contributed to this process.

[02:05:40] With that being said, as a matter of fact, I did believe you did say yesterday, Mr. Ellis, that we've had the greatest involvement, greatest participation ever in this standard setting process. And I think that says a lot. I think that's definitely representative of the hard work that we all collectively put in to ensure that we had absolute maximum participation by all the stakeholders throughout this process.

[02:06:05] i heard earlier uh some comments from some members of the public uh one gentleman mentioned uh that he's concerned about jobs leaving virginia going elsewhere because they are not qualified enough qualified students qualified individuals for certain roles i also heard from the executive director of the state council of higher education he talked about how our kids our students are not

[02:06:38] prepared when they come on to college campuses. And I can say that I don't think we can say with great honesty and sincerity that if that we really care and that we really want equal opportunity for all students, no matter where they live, no matter their community, and not best position them to compete for the opportunities for future opportunities as adults that will be available

[02:07:09] to them we can and we should raise expectations our kids are capable i'm gonna say it again our kids are very capable and so we should definitely certainly set the ball bar excuse me higher and there's no doubt in my mind that they will raise rise to the challenge and as a result we will be honest with them in terms of their individual proficiencies as a result of the work that we do today we know our

students will make the necessary academic adjustments we know that the work that we do will help identify what supports they need in order to ultimately be

[02:07:49] academically successful and meet the expectations that we separate them and we know at the end they will make us proud but it starts with the work that we do today to set that bar to raise those expectations and ensure that they're prepared for all the future opportunities that exist once they graduate from high school and so that is our role and I take my role and I'm sure we all do very seriously and we're going to do this for the kids and the school children as they someday become

[02:08:17] successful adults. Thank you. Big decision, new board member, but agree with the comments that others have shared as well. At the end of the day, education is about lifting people up, right? That's the strongest thing that we can do, but change is hard and I recognize that. Some of the feedback that I've heard from the field is, what are about those graduation rates? How does this impact seniors or sophomores. And the board is looking at that, talking about phased approaches,

[02:08:52] opportunities. But change is hard, but it's needed. And it's something that we collectively can do. And Mr. Hansen mentioned some of the stats over the years and folks are saying, hey, we need more dollars. Well, if you look back since 2013 for inflation, I think he shared this, up 35% of dollars in Virginia. Well, we need more staff. Well, if you look from 2014 to now, We're up 31% in teachers, 50% in all other areas outside of teacher aides, up 19%.

[02:09:22] So staff, funding, and then there's more. The work that the superintendent, her team, our COO, its deputy soup, all of that is on the way and already happening. We saw new jobs posted to help with regional supports and just-in-time efforts.

[02:09:38] So those pieces are, if not already there, continuing to be developed and supported for local districts. But the reality is at the end of the day, education is about lifting people up and we can't just do it as a board. It's not a left and right issue. It's a bipartisan approach.

[02:09:55] And so if we're not all in, whether it's a local school district, a teacher in classroom 500, this board, we've got to be all in for helping students. And so that, as we think about this today and vote on it, but as the field looks at this, I just encourage folks to see this as an opportunity to help young people to get together, say, how can we as educators, as superintendents, as whoever you may be as a parent, take people, take our young people from where they are now to where they can be?

[02:10:29] Because we all know with high expectations, they'll rise to those opportunities and looking forward to seeing what that looks like down in the next pipeline. Ms. Ashton? Yep, I'll try to be brief. I also just want to echo the appreciation for President Creasy, Superintendent Galton, and to the staff. I don't know if I'm an old board member or a new board member. I know I'm a parent, I'm a principal, I'm a Virginia resident, and the message that I want the public and everyone to hear is that this board believes in our kids.

[02:11:05] We believe in our superintendents. We believe in our principals. We believe that we can do hard things. And yes, I am sitting here thinking, I'm like, let's just have some context here. We've gone through a global pandemic, social unrest, low standards. We have done hard things and we can do this as a hard thing and change is hard.

[02:11:29] But as I'm sitting here, I think that we have to understand that no one can do it by themselves. We need to be partners in this work. And I can't think of what better prepares partners to do the work,

which is real good data that provides transparency around where our kids are.

[02:11:48] And I appreciate the team and staff saying like, hey, we're going to give this information to the principals before it goes public, because that's what good principals want is good data. It takes time to bring about change. It takes time to be able to make sense of it.

[02:12:05] And so I appreciate the team's response to we're going to respond to the data. We're going to respond to this request for help. I think that cannot be insignificant. And what I hope the final message is, is that we believe that we can do this and that this board has come together along with staff and stakeholders and that the time is now to move forward as urgently and as thoughtfully as possible to make sure that every child in Virginia has a chance to reach their full potential.

[02:12:39] Superintendent Gallickson. Oh, I'm sorry. Last one. That's Kilgore. And there's been so many great things said that I, you know, I can't really, I don't I don't see the point in repeating everything that's been said. Totally agree with everything I've heard. I have been an educator for 36 years, or I was an educator for 36 years, and I always believed it was a calling.

[02:13:05] I always believed that if you really believed in what you were doing, you were there for the right reason. And I know so many educators across the state of Virginia who have that same calling and who have that same passion. And while I've been on the board, I've been so amazed by the level of passion that I've seen continued by my fellow board members, by this state staff.

[02:13:29] I've told them over and over again, because I believe in giving people flowers while they're living, that it has been, I've been so impressed with the level of passion and belief in our young people that this state staff and everybody on this board has.

[02:13:43] I also realized as being I'm the only person on the board who came straight out the classroom and I say that because sometimes when I first came on board that was intimidating to me but I have seen since I've been here that it was really an asset because I came you know I was last from the classroom and so as a former teacher I did not serve as administrator that was not my calling I can understand how fellow teachers across Virginia will be overwhelmed by this change because as somebody said change is always, none of us like change, but those same educators and those same administrators

[02:14:22] who believe it is a calling for what they're doing, believe in our students, and they know that we have to improve for our students. And I've always said that there's nothing more important, there's no more, there's no career more important than educating our students and teaching them to become citizens productive citizens to have careers to have families whatever they choose to do in life and at the end of the day all that's been said let me just end it with that's what our goal is our goal is to raise our students up so when they leave the school system they are either

[02:14:59] ready to enter college they're ready to go in the workforce and we've heard so many so many comments about how we are failing them right now and none of us want to do that so I am so proud of the state team that is being very transparent they're willing to go out into the field not just you know not just make a mandate and say okay local school systems do however you however you can get there do it they're willing to go out and meet with them and talk with them stand shoulder to shoulder with them and that shouldn't be lost in the media or whenever this is talked about it's going to be a

[02:15:35] team effort. It's not going to be just pass this and then we're going to, you know, just let you do whatever. They're going to be there with them. And that means a lot. And I hope that educators across

Virginia hear that. So when they're worried and, you know, and concerned about how to implement this, they know there's going to be financial support and there's going to be team support with them the whole time. President Creasy, members of the board, I want to thank Governor Youngkin and the board over the last three and a half years, including members who are not here

[02:16:14] today, because you have been laying the foundation for restoring excellence in our public schools and to have high expectations of every student, starting with infants, with our early childhood system, all the way through our adult learners. And this is arguably the most critical vote that this board will take because it reaffirms the Commonwealth of Virginia's commitment to our students and their future. And I am excited that every parent in the Commonwealth and teacher and principal and superintendent, and most importantly, students will have the confidence that as they

[02:16:53] walk across that stage, they know that it means that they are truly ready for the pathway that they are being called to pursue. We throw around a lot 3E readiness. You heard a presentation about it yesterday that our students are rising to these higher expectations. They are taking more advanced classes in middle school. They are saying yes to college credits in high school. They are saying yes to higher quality work-based learning experiences. They are saying yes

[02:17:26] to apprenticeships. They are saying yes to industry-recognized credentials that ensure that they are day one ready in a career. And they're saying yes and demonstrating readiness for multiple pathways in any of our military branches and service opportunities in the future.

[02:17:46] And so when we have challenged our educators and our students with more rigorous standards, They got to work, and our team has ruthlessly been coming alongside with high-quality instructional materials, upskilling of new instructional coaches, really leaning in on what other toolkits, what other technical coaching can we provide to help you deliver even more for every one of your students.

[02:18:16] And I think every agency head would say this, but I feel strongly about it because I get the opportunity to meet multiple times a month with every agency head who leads all of the Commonwealth's education agencies and workforce agencies.

[02:18:35] And we are a united set of executives that see what is possible for Virginia. We have planted the flag across secretariats and agencies to say Virginia will be the top state for talent. And it starts with us, with our littlest learners all the way through our K-12 pipeline.

[02:18:56] And you heard from some of them today that this is essential for us to remain competitive and for our students to truly be able to lead emerging industries that are just coming online in Virginia, to ensure national security, to deliver on whatever those goals and aspirations that they have, and that they will have the confidence, they have the skills, knowledge, critical thinking skills, say, yes, I can do that. And so for me, it is so invigorating to see the

[02:19:32] transformation of our agency that we are completely overhauling from only on compliance to really breaking down silos. Data has never been more exciting because teams are collaborating and know that this is going to drive actions and that we are going to better empower educators with real supports. And seeing our longtime staff at the department really step up with new solutions to say, this is what we're hearing. It's worth us pursuing because it's grounded in evidence and

[02:20:07] grounded in research and we're not only growing talent within but we're also recruiting subject matter experts because people around the country are excited that virginia is is renewed hope around what is possible for our students and um i think you are going to be amazed as you continue to hear each month about the supports that are being provided to our students how we are better using the billions of dollars that have been invested in our k-12 system more than 50 percent in just four years and most importantly how it's working for kids and where we need to pivot and

[02:20:43] adapt and so i can affirm uh especially off of the energy from our all staff last week that um the doe team i mean we're winning emmys so we are uh we are firmly committed um to coming alongside all of our communities across the commonwealth and delivering for our students they've never been more focused on what's possible for students and every single employee at the department of ed believes that every student can deliver and so i thank the board for prioritizing

[02:21:20] the raising of expectations for all of our students and also the opportunity for us to hit the road and get continued input and come back with the best implementation plan possible and with that i will pass okay so um now i will renew my request for a motion or what it has been moved and seconded gosh that was so long ago uh so dr ackerman hi mr green uh dr northern hi mr

[02:21:51] hansen miss mcpherson aye miss kilgore ah miss ashton aye mr monk aye and chair votes aye thank you uh item d miss verda good morning president creasy members of the board superintendent gullickson for the record i am christina burda the proud chief operations officer for the department

[02:22:30] of ed before you today are the final reasons for the guidelines for the school construction assistance program for the 2024 to 2026 biennium as a reminder school divisions and regional cte programs apply for funding through this designated open application periods and are awarded funding based on 10 20 or 30 percent of the approved project cost depending on the division's local composite index and the locality's fiscal stress categories. Another benefit of the program is that there is no local match required for this funding that is awarded. Following the first review at

[02:23:09] your August board meeting, we heard your feedback loud and clear and have incorporated those additional revisions into the draft guidelines before you today. I am going to highlight the additional revisions that were made since August for you. We have added language requiring schools funded by the SCAP grant to be scheduled to remain open for at least five years, including locations where decreasing enrollment may result in school consolidation and closing. So we will have them affirm for us that they are not in a spot where they're subject to be consolidating or closing schools. We have added language encouraging innovative and creative solutions

[02:23:48] for the use of underutilized space, flexible learning models such as a school within a school concept or public micro schools and considering the consolidation of undercapacity schools as a means to use best best use available resources we have added the recognized flexible space concepts to allow for innovative facility solutions we have added language to provide divisions the opportunity to earn points if they are renovating space or leveraging flexible models after school consolidations or closures happen. We are adding language to include the use of blending and

[02:24:27] braiding of funds, seeking business and industry in-kind contributions, or using other allowable grant resources to supplement their school construction grant facilities funding. We have also looked into the department's building condition criteria and removed age of building as a factor on all three categories, good, fair, and poor. Also in criteria one of the application, we have added an opportunity

for three points to be assigned for building enhancements and flexible space concepts after a school division has gone through a full consolidation or school

[02:25:03] closure. It is recommended today that the Board of Ed consider these proposed amendments for the School Construction Assistant Program Guidelines for Binding of 24 to 26. I will also reaffirm for you that these are going to be constant conversations we have. I can tell you from the time that you started with these guidelines we have greatly expanded the program in part to your feedback but also the feedback from our stakeholders and so kudos to you for the work we will continue to enhance this as well in future iterations that come before you happy to answer any questions

[02:25:40] thank you miss murder are there any questions mr monk thank you first just want to share excited to see some of the feedback around individual ct programs implemented and so So appreciate that, appreciate the team's work and including those.

[02:25:56] I think that will be another opportunity for local districts to be able to continue progress on our 3E framework there and allow specific changes within districts that maybe they wouldn't have the chance to do without these funds.

[02:26:13] A little clerical question around the maximum of five points for a school division or regional CT program that has not been awarded the fund before trying to I know that they can have up to three applications but just trying to understand why that change of if the school are those five points per school that hasn't been awarded before do you know yeah it used to be division awards and because we've expanded it so they can have multiple school awards in qualification for the program we wanted to make it very clear that it's not just the school division if they had a school

[02:26:50] that was achieving an award that in the past two years that they if they haven't excuse me received an award in the past two years they got points trying to expand again across oops sorry across the funding across the commonwealth to make sure that we are providing access to all 131 school districts wonderful and then we just wanted to commend as well the addition thank you president creasy um the additional uh you talked about whether it's industry support or blending and in braiding of funds. We talked a little yesterday, Perkins is one of those great opportunities to potentially add some funds in there that could help support these. And so seeing,

[02:27:27] you know, divisions as part of their application include these on their Perkins plan. I think that's just a great blending and opportunity for students. So applaud the efforts and excited to support it. Thank you. And just for clarity as well, because I'm always talking about the technical support and we're looking at this more than just a compliance agency. Once you adopt these, it is our intent to have a lunch and learn or a webinar with school divisions so they can understand kind of our concept and thoughts and understand the changes to make sure that we can have maximum applications. Other questions here? Okay. Is there a motion to approve the proposed amended guidelines

[02:28:05] for school construction program for the 2426 biennium? So move. Second. Any discussion here? Dr. Ackerman. Aye. Mr. Green. Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Mr. Hanson. I think he's.

[02:28:22] Ms. McPherson. Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Ms. Ashton. Aye. Mr. Monk. Aye. And Chair votes aye. Thank you, Ms. Verda. Thank you. Okay. And I think you have item E as well. Yes, ma'am. Thank you, President Creasy. Before you today is a request for the first and final review of recommendations regarding the literary loan applications for the release of literary loan funds. As a reminder regarding this funding

stream, these are loans to school divisions that are available to utilize and leverage the Commonwealth's Virginia, the Great Commonwealth

[02:28:57] of Virginia's bond rating, and the loans must be repaid to the literary fund over an approved term of principal and interest payments. So these are not grants that you are awarding, these are loans specifically for school divisions. Before you today are four literary loan approvals applications for your approval first is an application that was presented to you in your august meeting but there were additional questions regarding the application that we contacted giles to discuss the loan is requested by giles county for the purpose of the renovation of existing classrooms in addition to accommodate up to 11 classrooms which will replace existing

[02:29:33] modular classrooms renovating and replacing the elevator and upgrades to the safe school entrance and improvements at the macy mcclarity elementary school you requested additional information from the division before proceeding with the loan approval and we have received additional contacts from giles county for you the county's current grade structure is k through 7 and 8 through 12. they are reviewing the grade structure and the macy mcclarity elementary school as a result may get additional students giles county has also indicated that there are a couple of new school subdivisions that are coming close to the county line with these new housing

[02:30:10] opportunities, it is anticipated that these subdivisions will generate some growth in their student population. Giles County is requesting a literary fund loan for the project in the amount of $12,475, payable over 30 years and is eligible for a 2% annual loan interest rate. There are three additional loan applications before you for consideration and approval, the first being a loan requested by Pennsylvania County for the purpose of installing a new HVAC system, new electrical transformer, new acoustic ceiling tiles, replacing exterior windows, and the work to bury a hydroponic

[02:30:49] piping and electrical utility lines at John L. Hurt Elementary School. Pennsylvania County is requesting a literary fund loan for this project in the amount of $8,228,000 payable over 18 years and is eligible for a 2% annual loan interest rate. We did clarify with them because all of HVAC money was applied during the pandemic. They've used that for many of their other schools.

[02:31:16] These are elementary schools that they didn't have enough funding from that source to utilize, so they're leveraging the literary loan to accomplish that project. The next application is also from Pennsylvania County for the purpose of installing a new HVAC system, a new electrical transformer, a new acoustical tile, and replacing exterior windows, burying a hydroponic piping, and electrical utilities at Chatham Elementary School.

[02:31:39] Pennsylvania County is requesting a literary loan for the project in the amount of $7,018,000, payable over 18 years, and is eligible for a 2% annual loan interest rate. The last project is a loan requested by Culpeper County for the purpose of building a new elementary school of 89,000 square feet and an operating capacity of 650 students in grades pre-K through grade 5.

[02:32:07] Culpepper County is requesting a literary loan for the project in the amount of $25 million, payable over 20 years, and is eligible for a 3% annual interest rate. This is due to increased enrollment in their locality. The Superintendent of Public Instruction recommends that the board waive first review and approve the release of these literary fund loans requested by school divisions based on the loan amounts, terms, and eligible annual interest rates requested in their loan application and included in your executive summary of the board agenda item.

[02:32:38] I'm happy to answer any questions you may have. Are there any questions here for Ms. Berta, Dr. Northern? - So just to clarify, and thank you for the follow up with Giles. I know that was my question and replacing those modulars, that makes me understand that better.

[02:32:57] And then Culpeper, it's a new elementary school totally. So it would have to, I mean, enroll. I mean, do they have an enrollment plan? That's kind of, I mean, or is there an elementary school that's going to be closing? I guess a little more context about that new elementary school that they're anticipating that much increased enrollment.

[02:33:14] They are seeing increased growth in their community that warrants a new elementary school. That is the feedback that we receive. I'm looking at my director of support services, Vijay Ramderain. Is that correct, Vijay? Yeah, it's just sheer growth in their community, new subdivisions, and they need a new elementary school.

[02:33:32] Further questions? Comment. Ms. McPherson? Yeah, along these lines, apparently you've done your due diligence as far as building a new school. So they had a comment yesterday, and i want to make sure that we did it publicly one of the things the board will be looking at is making sure that we don't necessarily fund new buildings that are displaced in schools that could be saved that would be disruptive to the students and busing students for a long period of time so as you go through the analysis is really important obviously we understand that there's

[02:34:09] unused space that can be retrofitted for other things and that we have built into the regulations um things that could be done with that space but i'm very concerned about making sure that schools don't just decide that they want to build one big structure that is to the detriment of a lot of communities um so continue to do your due diligence in the area and make sure that we're well aware of why they're asking for funding for a brand new facility yes ma'am additional

[02:34:44] questions or comments here okay um is there a motion to waive first review and approve the release of the literary fund loans requested by the school divisions based on the loan amounts terms and eligible annual interest rates requested in their loan applications as indicated in the item presented here to the board so move second any discussion here dr ackerman aye mr green

[02:35:16] Dr. Northern hi Mr. Hanson maybe Miss McPherson hi Miss Kilgore um Miss Ashton hi Mr. Monk hi and chair votes aye thank you okay um do we want to take this one okay um so we will take item F and then um at the conclusion of this item we will take our lunch but I'll let everybody know that again once we conclude this item Mr. Chapman Thank you so much, President Creasy, Vice President Hanson, members of the board and Superintendent Gullickson.

[02:35:54] In addition to the work that the board does here, the board has a number of advisory committees that help the board to accomplish work. Today, we have some nominees for vacancies on the Virginia Advisory Committee for Advanced Learning, which is one of the board's advisory committees that was set up in 2024.

[02:36:13] The two nominations include Christopher Tabby, who currently serves as the Gifted Coordinator for Salem City Public Schools. He works closely with Gifted Coordinators in Region 6 for thought partnership and program alignment, and this will be his second term if accepted on VACAL.

[02:36:28] And he's being nominated as a Region 6 Employer Administrator affiliated with the Gifted or Advanced Academic Programming. The second nominee is Gail Statton, who currently serves as the Gifted

Coordinator for Greensville County Public Schools. She also serves as the secretary for the Virginia Association of the Gifted, and this would be her first term on VACAL if accepted.

[02:36:49] She's being nominated for a Region 8 employee or administrator affiliated with gifted or advanced academic programming. The superintendent's recommendation is that the board waive first review and approve these recommended nominees to fill the vacancies on the Virginia Advisory Committee for Advanced Learning. Any questions for Mr. Chapman?

[02:37:07] Is there a motion to waive first review and approve the recommended nominees to fill the vacancies on VACAL? so moved second any discussion here dr northern oh i'm voting no discussion i'm sorry okay all right uh dr ackerman i mr green uh dr northern i miss mcpherson i miss kilgore uh miss ashton

[02:37:39] i mr monk all right and chair votes i okay we will take a lunch break now and come back at 12 15.

[02:37:48] thank you okay good afternoon we are back um and we will begin here with item g

[03:38:07] calypso gillstrap is going to talk to us about um modernizing our mops mops my favorite topic is this okay great good is it afternoon it's afternoon good afternoon president creasy superintendent gullickson and members of the board i'm calypso gillstrap executive director of the office of innovation and with me i have mr reginald fox he's our educational technology specialist and used to be a mop himself he used to run the york county mop and then i also have sophia mcdaniel with us our director of innovative models and policy

[03:38:43] in the office of innovation so here to help support our process so today i'm going to be presenting on a proposed update to our mop or multi-division online provider process for 2025 and these updates reflect our commitment to providing that high quality virtual learning experience and also realigning what we do to the board strategic priorities so on slide two the revised multi-division online provider process is intentionally aligned with the board of education's 24 to 29 comprehensive plan reinforcing the commonwealth's commitment to access innovation

[03:39:20] and accountability it expands access to our high quality virtual instruction for all students including those in a non-traditional setting and supporting innovative instructional models that reflect the needs of today's learners. Our annual monitoring and clearly defined revocation procedures strengthen the oversight, while transparency requirements ensure families and divisions can make more informed decisions. The process also brings clarity to our formalized timelines, review structures, and appeals procedure. Importantly, that supports our workforce readiness by aligning virtual instruction to our Virginia standards of learning and our career and and technical education competencies,

[03:39:59] helping our students prepare for life in the military, college, careers, and beyond. So we also needed to bring this forward because we have new legislation in Senate. Oh, sorry, I skipped a slide. The background, you guys probably wanna know about the MOP to begin with.

[03:40:14] The multi-online provider process was established in response to the Virginia General Assembly to expand high quality virtual learning opportunities in K through 12 students for the Commonwealth. Originally, this process was adopted on November 18th, 2010.

[03:40:32] So we've been doing this for 15 years. The process was designed to ensure that our virtual programs meet the rigorous standards of instructional quality, the staffing, and alignment with the Virginia Standards of Learning. Since its inception, the Department of Education has approved 30 providers, and we currently have 22 active providers.

[03:40:55] In 24-25 school year, we had over 15,000 students that were enrolled in a MOP. Most of those students are full-time, taking more than 54,000 courses and in 82 school divisions. So this really is robust in Virginia.

[03:41:14] This also shows that we have big scale and we need to make sure we modernize our process. Over the last 15 years, the online learning landscape has shifted, driven by technology innovation, increase student demand, and the need for more flexible instructional models.

[03:41:30] As highlighted in the 2024 Annual Report on the Condition and Needs of Public Schools, the board prioritized transparency, high expectations, and student outcomes across all of our environments, including the virtual ones. This proposed update reflects the commitment and position Virginia has to lead the quality of the future in online education.

[03:41:49] We also have new legislation, House Bill 2640, and this will, that has asked for us to become better at reflecting best practices with our policy expectations. The mandates are about growing the demand for high-quality online options, and that makes it even more essential that we modernize the process. The updated process strengthens oversight, improves transparency, and ensures that all students, regardless of their location or circumstance, have the opportunity to engage in rigorous, standard-designed virtual instruction. It also provides clearer expectations for providers and school divisions aligning with the Board of Education's priorities

[03:42:28] and our long-term vision for digital learning. So you're probably asking, what is a MOP? So a MOP can be a private or non-profit organization that contracts with school divisions to provide online instruction to students across division boundaries. Or it can be a school division that already has an online instructional program, but they want to expand past their own division geographic boundaries. So we have examples of that in Chesterfield and York, and then our other 18 providers are all those private or non-profit organizations. The three things they have to have

[03:43:05] is they have to align with the Virginia standards of learning. Every single course, there's about 60,000 of them that are approved. They're all aligned with SOLs. They also have to meet the accreditation staffing and instructional quality that a traditional school would have, and it has to be taught by a Virginia licensed teacher. What it is not is if less than 10% of the students are outside their division, or if it's a joint effort between a division and a limited out-of-boundary enrollment, or a program that is offered through a higher education institute like our lab schools.

[03:43:39] That would not be considered a model, even though it's multi-divisional and it could be online. So the Virginia Department of Education, what we do is we provide the process. So we approve them, We put all of the website information up, and then we provide a board report to you guys so you can see what we're doing.

[03:44:00] We also support the Virtual Learning Advisory Committee, and we help hundreds of families every year navigate virtual learning programs, including our MOPs. We also talk to a lot of school superintendents about their virtual options. Local school boards implement virtual learning by

contracting with the MOP, and then they post those courses online, clarify if there's any fees, which most of the time there's not any fees, and then they also set the criteria for if a student can take a virtual program or not.

[03:44:29] No matter what, they all have to meet the legal requirement for instruction and student support, just like any traditional school. So the MOPS cycle is grounded in the legislation which mandated that the Superintendent of Public Instruction develop and then the Board of Education approve a system for ensuring that there is a quality and accountability of these virtual learning programs.

[03:44:49] The process begins with an annual application cycle in which applicants submit a detailed documentation demonstrating compliance with our criteria. These include accreditation, organizational stability, quality staffing, data reporting capabilities, and alignment with our SOLs.

[03:45:07] So we've had 30 of those applicants. Applications are then reviewed by our multidisciplinary committee, and then the superintendent makes a final decision on if they can become a MOP. Once they've become a MOP, then we ask for an annual report, and that's kind of a little bit of what we're changing today, which I'll talk about more.

[03:45:26] So this annual monitoring is basically they turn in data to us to show that they still meet the criteria that we originally set. We also then have a virtual learning advisory committee meeting twice a year where we review courses they advise us on different new strategies and they give us input to improve that quality and access that virtual learning advisory committee has superintendents from each region we have some of our mops on there the couple of big organizations that are in our state so if a provider falls short like after they turn in their monitoring report or if any at any time if we're getting lots of

[03:46:03] complaints through those kind of things they can be put on a provisional status during that provisional status that limits if they can enroll new students or enter any new contracts we do work really hard to resolve those probationary things we're not there to like compliance it's more like okay you guys don't meet the criteria let's wrap around you and see what we can do to help you get get you back up to the criteria and if they consider if they continue and do not meet the standard then we do revoke their ability to be a provider in which case they would start all over again at the end of the year which is about this time we are working on gathering all the

[03:46:39] information from pop from the mops the school divisions that use them and then also our own data to create a annual report for the condition and needs of public schools in virginia and you can see that we have 15 well 14 of those if you want to read those uh that's where ai comes in put those into ai it gives you nice nice summary all right so what we're asking for with this new process so the current process has not been revised since 2010 it's the original so we think things have changed a little bit we would like to see clearer expectations so simply put this update

[03:47:13] modernizes the process to align with what is best practice and also make sure that it's transparent consistent and we want to realign with student-centered learning so the application and process sorry application process and criteria are designed to ensure that only high quality well-prepared providers are approved to deliver virtual instruction across virginia each applicant must demonstrate compliance with a comprehensive set of criteria that reflect both statutory requirements and best practices in online education. So to begin, providers must show that they are accredited by a recognized agency, not accredited by the VDOE, but like one of those

[03:47:51] big organizations that approve schools. Two, they have to have organizational stability. We want to make sure that they are financially solvent and have a clear governance structure so that they have a sustainable operation during the school year. Three, we have to make sure that they're staffing. They must have licensed teachers from Virginia, and they have to be endorsed in their content area, and their administrators must have advanced degrees with relevant leadership, so they have the highest quality, just like a school would. Three, next would be data reporting. Both, they have to be able to report their data to us, but also to the school divisions that they're

[03:48:29] serving. They also must be held accountable. So all of their instruction must align with the Virginia standards of learning, the standards of accreditation, and they must be able to test their students just like every other kid. And then their applicants must be grounded in research, best practices designed for the needs of all learners in those environments. So our virtual learning programs are definitely the highest expectations of virtual learning environments.

[03:48:55] they're using those engagement strategies of virtual learning. And last, they must address technology infrastructure and support. Providers are expected to have reliable systems for course delivery and management, offering technical support in a timely manner, and have a disaster recovery plan to ensure the continuity of learning. So one of my mops the other day bragged that they did not have a single snow day last year because kids in virtual learning don't get snow days, I guess as a whole school. So all of this comes together to make a new, more modern standards

[03:49:28] aligned board realignment of our process. So basically what's new, we have extended the application window before it was very rigorous. It was like for 30 days, this will happen. And then for 45 days, this will happen. And then within 15 days, this will happen. We got rid of all that. It's a 90 day window. People turn stuff into us and we will work with them. We also changed all the language to be less arbitrary and more like the goal is to make sure we're ready for the next school year. So as long as we are on track for that, that's the application window. We also expanded our review committees. When we first started this, it was a very small program. So we

[03:50:06] have now asked for the review committee to be bigger with people in finance, people in data, people with technology expertise, people maybe that have virtual learning experience now. So we want to have more experts, not just a few of us in the innovation office, kind of looking at the applications. We want to have more cross-agency stuff. Before, there was a three-year monitoring window, so you would turn in your reports to us, but we only looked at them every three years.

[03:50:29] We're going to look at everybody's reports every year now. Dive in. We are also being a little more strict about what's happening during provisional status. So before, it's kind of like, you're on provisional status. Good luck. We're now saying we need to wrap around those mops and make sure that they get back up to snuff faster and also put it back into a partnership with us.

[03:50:50] uh we have updated the appeals process to better align with the current virginia um appeals process act or appeal no what is it sophia non-procedural thank you very much administrate all right so that's why we have to have sophia and the team and then um to get all into the technical stuff they have to basically be accessible to our students at the highest level so they have to to be SCORM compliant and all the other web accessibility stuff because they are a big mop and they are now going to have to deliver those systems and work with our systems that already exist, like our statewide learning management system and open educational resources.

[03:51:32] Okay. So for stakeholder engagement, this is up for first review. So our proposed updates were not developed in a vacuum. We've had 15 years to work on them. They are a result of years and years and years of daily stakeholder engagement with local school division that divisions we were very purposeful in our last vlac meeting to make sure that we talked to them about this we've talked to our instructional technology leaders we talked to parents and students all the time so it's important to understand that these revisions maybe we don't have the uh complete administrative process act like we didn't go out for public hearings and those kind of things yet but this

[03:52:10] is because we've done the work every day our feedback comes from the daily every day so we are also wanting to make sure that we're responsive quickly to house bill 2640 and also your priorities as we have just updated quite a few of our standards and our accreditation system and those kind of things so to make sure that we are 3e ready this next school year we need to revise this process before january when we get our new application window so to um what would happen if if we pass this, one, we're going to have more high quality virtual learning instruction. Two, we're going to have more transparency so that parents can make better decisions and our

[03:52:47] superintendents better understand what it means when we hire a MOP. And then last, with our providers, clearer expectations, more support from BDOE when they enter into the interest of becoming a MOP. So if we pass this, to ensure a smooth transition, the Virginia Department of Education will have a series of coordinated supports and resources. We are currently right now creating a virtual learning index to help track what every single school division is doing with their virtual learning program. So we're going to have this massive, like nice spreadsheet of, you know, ACOMAC is doing these things for virtual learning and making sure we understand they're using these MOPS in this way, or maybe they're using virtual Virginia, or they might

[03:53:27] have a private entity that they're using. So we want a lot of our school divisions have also moved having their own academies inside their own school division and they're being really successful then we will make sure that all of our map data is more transparent on our annual report we will um we are we've already updated our website quite a bit to be way more transparent we've made a virtual learning for families webpage to help them navigate the mop process we have a query tool now so you can look for a course and it'll tell you what mop is offering that course and in which school divisions we will also have fall webinars for our school divisions for our applicants that are hoping to become a mop and also our current

[03:54:05] providers we are going to do more with frequently asked questions more application walkthroughs just more technical support for everyone in the field in january our goal would be to launch the 90-day application window and then next summer we'll start our monitoring process and our 2026 board report will reflect this new process so thank you so much for your time i know mops is a really really complex thing. I've been here for three years and I just now feel like I kind of understand it. So if you have questions, we're happy to answer them. So I brought the experts with us today and I kindly ask that you would approve for first review to take this up. And so we can

[03:54:42] continue the conversation and update our process from 2010 to 2025. I'm now happy to take your questions or your comments. So Calypso, I'll go first because I live in this world and I have some feedback for you guys that I think is going to probably make your lives a ton easier. And it's going to probably align nicely with the direction that you all are going in. So we can talk about that offline. But I did want to ask a couple of questions that I think are probably really

[03:55:16] important publicly here. And that is that how are we ensuring so well, let me let me step back and ask. We used to have on the old website, it was a list of large providers. So you had your Western Association of Schools and Colleges, anything that any virtual program they accredited was then approved by VDOE. That seems to have gone away. Is that correct? Yes. Okay. So all of those just blanket approved. We just updated. It's on the application. Okay. So you're not

[03:55:52] giving a blanket approval anymore to those big? Those were, no, those were always, it was more in the application process. And if somebody turned in an application, it was in the form that they filled out. We just didn't have it on the website. So that has always had to be accredited. That was always, we have not ever, even if it came off the website, we never diverted from the original process. No, what I mean is you had that list of those programs that you just gave a blanket get approval to instead of just the, so it was in addition to the courses, if those were approved by, if those programs were approved by any of those organizations, it was like a check.

[03:56:31] You don't need to do anything else. Then was this long list of all of the individual courses. Has that list of providers gone away? Reggie probably knows that better because he's the technical person. And he's also been here doing the work. You know what I'm talking about, right?

[03:56:48] Morning. Yes. Okay. No, we replaced some other important information on the website that would be more helpful to MOPs, those looking at becoming a MOP. But we have on the application all of the agencies that could be used as the accreditation. We have not deleted any of the additional requirements. In addition to the accreditation, there's still sustainability, there's accountability, there's curriculum, there's staffing. All of those requirements are still there.

[03:57:27] Okay. So follow-up question. If we are requiring Virginia licensure, how are we ensuring that those courses that are being delivered, let's say I'm delivering X course for a broad-based approved provider, right? How are we as the department ensuring that that course that's being delivered by Debbie Kilgore, who may live in Arizona, has a Virginia teaching license or that the provider

[03:58:03] hasn't said, uh-oh, Debbie can't teach this now, you know, Mache is teaching it. How are we monitoring that to ensure compliance with what we are asking you can answer it i know the answer well i just want to say since i yeah yeah i did this work for 35 years uh and we used to have spreadsheets that we tried to maintain uh that but now that we have a partnership and as calypso talked about expanding our relationship with other departments uh mr gillstrap's department

[03:58:41] It has increased the quality and the oversight, ensuring that we require the MOPS to have Virginia licensed teachers. And there is now a database, there's technology to help us, and we're able to find that information.

[03:59:00] We're able to put in a name. And that's one of the requirements of the MOPS. so we ensure that their names of all of their teachers are endorsed in the areas in which they teach. Okay. It's also gathered with the master schedule information that, so if a school division enters contract with that MOP, those teachers show up on the master schedule, and so it would flag in that system if they are not licensed, and so that goes kind of back, like, we kind of, of course partner with the mops and also with the the school division but there's also that contract

[03:59:38] between the school division and the mop that they have to work those kind of things out like the the data reporting part that i was talking about they have to prove to us that they're going to send their

data to the school division to be able to put it into the master schedule to ensure that that child is being taught with a course that's approved by us and also has a licensed teacher we have caught a couple of times once or twice uh people out of compliance and then that would be something that would stick them into probation if they violate that so follow-up question would be then sorry okay uh how are we ensuring so that's a that's a main school year type of a of a question

[04:00:16] or a answer there how are we ensuring that same thing for acceleration credits and for credit recovery summer courses so are we no matter what is happening they have to enroll in that school division okay so that we do not allow direct enrollment into a provider program they have to go through the school division first there is times when parents feel frustrated that a mop has a course that they want their child to take and that school division they live in does not accept that credit so that goes back to the board of the local school board's decision on whether

[04:00:53] they're going to verify that credit or not so i live in henrico county they may not accept virtual Virginia classes, even though I would like my child to take a virtual Virginia class, the local school board has the ultimate say. So if they decide to take an accelerated course during the summertime or get credit recovery, those type things, they need to, the parents have to work with their local school division to ensure that those kids are enrolled in the provider program that will be accepted by their local school division. And finally, I think this might be my last question for now. So some of these local school divisions like Hampton City

[04:01:29] schools that have, you know, created and continue to sustain their own programs. Have we had any conversations with them about what, if they are willing to be more broad-based, and so are they willing to support other students in other school divisions by way of their programs? What does that look like for some of our different school division partners that, of course, also have their own. So we have 10 virtual schools right now, and they would all be welcome to become mops.

[04:02:05] They have to reach outside of their school division at least 10%. So one of the problems we're having, like Chesterfield qualifies as a mop, but they are at capacity with their own children. And so they can't actually handle the capacity of reaching outside more than that 10%.

[04:02:22] So they used to be before COVID, we used to have a Chesterfield and York County used to be much bigger MOPS. Right now, it's just a marketplace question. But yes, if Hampton, Henrico, Giles, Pulaski are 10 virtual schools, if they want to become MOPS, we would highly encourage that. We do have relationships with those school divisions. And we're trying in our office, especially in response to this house bill, to create that virtual learning index. So we really understand where we know what our schools are. We know what our MOPS are. We know what virtual Virginia looks like what we don't know is the programs, the little tiny programs that are happening in those

[04:03:01] innovative models. That's where we kind of feel like we're not sure how they're delivering that instruction. And that's what we want to kind of dig into a little bit more. Okay. I lied. I have one more question. I'll talk about MOPs all day long. So just for the board's knowledge and understanding can you explain um how how virtual virginia and mops work in in collaboration or side by side just so that there's some understanding there um about stepping on toes

[04:03:35] not stepping on toes that kind of thing all right so we have luckily we have 1.4 million kids so there's lots of options and lots of different pathways we can take so i would say in the simplest of overview, the 10,000 foot is virtual Virginia is more like a traditional school and that you're taking one or two credits.

A kid is probably sitting in a physical classroom and they are delivering instruction through the virtual program. There's probably a mentor in the classroom and that kid is learning Spanish three because their school division doesn't have enough Spanish

[04:04:10] teachers, or they're taking, there could be 30 kids in a classroom taking 30 different classes, but they're still like sitting in a class. There's a 90 minute block. There's a mentor in the room. Mops are the opposite of that. Almost a hundred percent of their kids are full time and they are learning a hundred percent at home or on the road. Um, we have kids that are like in recovery programs, alternative programs. We have a kid who's a movie star. And so, and we have a kid is an international soccer player in our MOT program. So it just is 100%, oh sorry, it's 100%

[04:04:45] virtual and their parent is probably supporting them at home. We also have way more kids in K5 in our MOT program. Virtual Virginia has a very small amount of kids who are K5 full-time. So the MOT program is, I would say, more asynchronous, full-time. Virtual Virginia is more secondary, more traditional, what you would think of as a virtual class that you're taking at a certain time and you have a live instructor at that time. We also do have homeschool and private school that we talk to our families about quite a bit too. And then on top of that, we have our own school

[04:05:20] divisions, virtual programs, and they kind of are a mishmash of all those things. Sorry to take over that conversation with questions. You're, you're probably, you, if, hey, if you're looking for a We're probably looking for a virtual learning specialist when Reggie retires.

[04:05:37] Okay, Mr. Monk. Don't want to stand on the opportunity of a job there. Our student advisory committee has some questions around this or thoughts around it, and I'll leave it there.

[04:05:52] But how are we -- and I see here, and you've chatted a little bit about instructional quality and rigor. rigor. How is that being measured, not only on the forefront, but continually to ensure that it is maintained there? Yep. So we would look at those classes the same way as we do any class that's happening, any school, any program. We're getting the data, like when we get the raw data, we don't know that they're a virtual or a in-person or traditional kid. It comes in, and we start looking and digesting. What is nice is the school quality profile does have

[04:06:29] full-time virtual students have been pulled out and you can actually look at the mop data for just our virtual students we've done studies with rl sri i mean we've done all of that type of deep research to make sure our virtual programs are on par with all the rest of our programs i would say virtual learning is not a it's just a different way of teaching just like being in a class where you do hands-on sewing and cooking versus being in a math classroom where you're practicing and those type things it's just a way of delivering instruction and it's just as good

[04:07:05] or bad as any other instruction that's happening i think the marketplace takes care of mops that don't do a good job because that school division why would they hire a mop that's failing students so most of the time our mops outperform traditional school because parents are choosing to go into that program they're choosing to wrap around their kid and give support and it it's it's gonna have successful kids because those parents are super engaged in what they're learning and choosing to do so uh we do have 16 000 kids that we look at every year and again if they aren't

[04:07:43] performing well the school division comes in and helps that family and uh we are also keeping an eye on those classes i mean we review all 60 000 courses every year we review their test scores every

year we are really analyzing and digging into that data so uh i would say just like the office of accreditation accountability we are looking at those virtual programs the same way so follow up to um mr monk's question there sorry dr northern you're next um is we what we did hear from them was a was a lot around ap courses and so if we're only looking at let's say sol test

[04:08:22] outcomes are we also looking at the same time the amount of students that are taking an ap course through a mop and whether they are taking the ap exam and whether or not you know what that score was what that outcome was so are we gathering that data as well yes so in general students don't take AP and IB and the advanced class, they might be accelerated in a MOT program, but they're not taking advanced coursework in a MOT program. That's usually virtual Virginia. But yes, if we

[04:08:57] get that data, we are kind of relying on school divisions to report that data back to us because the way it comes into the agency is they took a virtual class. This is what their pass rate was. This is their pass rate. And then they took the test. Virtual Virginia really digs into that data. And they love to brag that they have higher test scores than the state average. The MOPs just don't have as many AP students as Virtual Virginia does because they are mostly the whole comprehensive education of a kid.

[04:09:30] you know they do have some ap courses i'd also say ap's keeping an eye on that they want to make sure that if they're a mop or virtual virginia and those school divisions are using them that they're taking the ap class i do think our new accreditation model is going to we're going to see that where they actually turn over and take it another thing that we like to track is did they persist so if they took ap computer science a are they taking ap computer science b what that's where actually we see the virtual programs really filling in the gaps is we offer computer science

[04:10:04] principles at our high school but we don't offer the second one and virtual virginia and our mop programs do so now here's an opportunity for that kid to take a class that we couldn't necessarily gather up all the kids or physics to or something where the kid can go ahead and persist from the introductory class they took at their high school to the class that maybe their course didn't offer Thank you. Dr. Northern? Yeah, I think what I'm hearing from my colleagues here is just the theme of quality and how do we define quality. I think a couple things that we've learned about virtual instruction post-COVID is that all kids don't do well in a virtual environment like some

[04:10:44] kids do and some kids don't. And so when I look at, and I'm so glad you guys have tightened the screws a little bit, but I would actually say that most of what we've got is inputs driven, even though we are collecting data. So what virtual teachers don't get that the brick and mortar do are the principal walkthroughs, right? The colleague conversations in the faculty room, right? Like you do pick up a lot of improvement in your instruction by being in a brick and mortar building. And so I wonder whether, I think it's also a little unfair that the online teacher

[04:11:20] wouldn't be subjected to an observation right similar to as teachers we get annual observations so is there a way i'm just gonna the stuff to look into is there a way for um us to actually you know virtually poke in the classroom and do an observation just as we would do in a brick and mortar classroom so that we can check on the integrity of that instruction is there a way that we can monitor the teacher student relationships just like we do in a brick and mortar? Can we, for instance, put in the contract that you have to have a certain amount of time of synchronous instruction? Doesn't have to be a lot, but I think that live time with your

[04:11:59] peers in the classroom and the teacher in live time and not just at two in the morning or whenever kids want to do something on their own. I mean, I think those are measures that we can build in on the contracting process with these providers. For instance, can we have an outcomes-based contract right so these are the metrics we want to see you uphold before your contract gets renewed um and that sort of thing i i just feel like there's got to be a way to actually peek in a little bit better on the quality and aside from a lot of these inputs driven compliance mechanisms i couldn't speak for video because we don't ever poke in but we also do not

[04:12:37] get into contract management between mop and school divisions we talk to mops we talk to school divisions, we talk to parents. We do not usually get into the middle of those three entities. We can certainly survey our school divisions better about what are the practices they're doing to make sure that those MOPS are high quality. And we certainly, since this is for first review, take that into consideration and go talk to our lawyers and see how they all feel about that.

[04:13:06] I know that has come up with our providers. Lawyers will definitely say no, but just push yourself to think about quality some in ways. I will say, I certainly, I do think that is happening between school divisions and MOPS. I just don't know if the role for VDOE is in there, but I also know we can go visit schools all the time and go visit their classrooms. So absolutely open to that conversation. I will say, I know Virtual Virginia, which is our program, is happy

[04:13:39] to have all of you poke in anytime you want and they do do student engagement and more um of that circle times and social times and they have their faculty actually go together and meet and those kind of things um so and have virtual trivia nights and murder mysteries and that kind of stuff i do not know about the 22 mops that we have though and reggie may be able to speak better to that especially our i know our local school divisions like chesterfield and york definitely do because their teachers actually live in virginia and those kind of things i also know our local school our 10 school divisions that have schools like um hemrico county their school division actually

[04:14:17] their teachers report to a building and are in a brick and mortar situation even though the students are virtual so do you want to say anything else reggie about okay all right i said did i misspeak about anything either yeah i just i think one comment and then i'll close i just think the um the what we've learned in the school choice domain is that the market always doesn't work as as we would anticipate because parents actually care about more sometimes than just you know test scores we know that um and so they care about caring teachers or they care about their kids are safe and all that's well and good um so they we might not weed out all of the providers

[04:14:55] who aren't serving kids well if we only rely on the market well we have documented all of our parent conversations so we have a call log of all of those and i will say although they call and complain sometimes in general they do talk about how much they care the teachers care about their kids get to know their kids and actually because they're in the virtual world they have more one-on-one time because of that asynchronous time so and most of our programs even if they are asynchronous they do have scheduled like a through l has to meet at this time and they have to be on the computer at a certain time and those kind of things so uh those are of course all qualitative

[04:15:34] and not quantitative and also we um we do collect parent survey data every year that is part of our process on the monitoring report but they're the mops are required to collect student and parent data on how they're feeling um so we do have feedback for that but we certainly can up that more and have

more um conversations with our providers and our school divisions on how they're doing observations and faculty collegiality things and making sure that our teachers stay engaged too great questions other questions other comments here okay thank you so much we will accept this

[04:16:13] item for first review and see you in october wonderful thank you mr gilstrap you have item h and item i good afternoon uh president creasy uh superintendent goldson members of the board i have two fun exciting items for you first one is one i bring to you generally about this time of year this is about our teacher education programs on new endorsement areas the regulations governing

[04:16:52] the review and approval of the education program in virginia requires that the virginia board of education approve requests from virginia institutions of higher education to add new endorsement programs. Request for new programs must be submitted annually by March 31st and these all were submitted in time. After we do that, after we received them, the BDO staff verify the program endorsement competencies through the review of course descriptions, syllabi to determine alignment, and regulatory criteria including supervised classroom instruction. The second page

[04:17:27] of your boilerplate has a list of some of the universities who have done this and the programs that they have asked for. We had a ABTEL board meeting at the beginning of September and they reviewed this as well and did make the recommendation to bring this to you all. We are bringing it as a first review. I just want to highlight a few things on the list. Emory and Henry University, this would bring them up to 35 programs if these are approved. As well, Longwood would be up to 30. Randolph-Macon College would be at 16.

[04:18:03] Shenandoah University 34, University of Mary Washington would be at 45 programs, University of Lynchburg 37, University of Richmond 37, University of Virginia 36 and VCU 33. Additionally if we were looking at the actual programs that are added, 14 of these are special population programs which is as you know one of our highest areas of need for teachers. This is encouraging that these colleges and universities would like to add these programs they only added them if they have students they want to put in them so that means that they are having an

[04:18:40] increased interest from their student population we have three of them that are based on literacy three of them for numeracy one school counseling for science and I think there is also a history in there as well the superintendent of public instruction recommends that the Virginia Board of education except for first review the advisory board on teacher education and licensure's recommendation to approve new education endorsement programs and i am available for questions

[04:19:13] and we'll also take comments any questions here dr northern this is maybe a dumb question but i mean if you are going to get an undergraduate in science and they've got um let's see we've got biology chemistry science like they've broken out every type of science i mean shouldn't you if going to teach science be able to teach biology chemistry multiple sciences or do we really like shouldn't there be some overlap between these subfields and science or like are these teachers going to get exposed to other types of science or just their one little narrow programmatic science so that that is probably also a change from when you and i attended school because it was just

[04:19:52] science and a science teacher was eligible to teach almost every science i will say in the the last few years, many of our teachers come out with specialty areas. I will say though that the curriculum does cross over on all of the other sciences as well, but it has heavily on biology.

[04:20:08] If it's for biology, it's heavily on physics if it's for physics. So there would still be some need for coursework if they were to teach the other courses, but I will say that many of our science teachers get their biology certification and then go and take the chemistry test so that they can teach chemistry or some of the other sciences because it makes them more marketable absolutely yeah yeah but in our world today there are many schools that if you're a biology teacher that you're only a biology teacher but across the commonwealth we have all different size schools and you may have one science teacher in that school and so they have to teach all the sciences

[04:20:43] I may I Dr. Ackerman I just to follow up on that it will also help with the teacher shortages if you have someone with only biology who wants to add a teacher certificate to their major. So where there's a shortage in some of the sciences and math, I think there's an opportunity here as well. So a lot of times it went from my time in higher ed, what is happening here is people are choosing a major, a very specific major, and then think, oh, I could add on that licensure to it. So other comments or questions here? Thank you. We will accept this

[04:21:20] item for first review. Okay. Thank you. The second item is the one I'm actually more excited about. One of the things I received the most outreach from the field is about Praxis test taking and how challenging some people find passing the Praxis test and many of them relay that they're one or two questions away from passing and how stressful it may have become for them.

[04:21:48] Many people talk about the test anxiety and so Praxis has addressed this issue with an opportunity for teachers who are close to passing. have to be within one standard measure of error and that would when we do our new test we usually give you that information so it would be like if you had to have a 151 it's going to be like 148 is going to be one standard we're talking a couple points at the most but if you're within that range they have a program and I'm going to read what I have written even though I'm getting too excited

[04:22:20] but i just need to get on task here during the april 2025 abtel meeting the director of educational partnerships with ets that's our praxis representative presented a new praxis alternative test program called the praxis bridge currently the virginia department of ed does not recognize this assessment option for educators to earn a virginia license adding this assessment option would provide an additional pathway allowing current and prospective teachers to substitute a passing score for the required curriculum in the code of virginia after completing supplemental

[04:22:57] training in the subject areas in which a passing score was missed by no more than one standard error of mean aptel reviewed received an initial presentation in april met again in september to decide if they would make the recommendation to the board of education to include this assessment option towards the Virginia license. I'll talk about the program here in a second. I will also say that the superintendent recommends that we take this for first review before we go any further, but this program basically takes the areas that you struggled in if you did not meet the mark.

[04:23:34] Say the cut score is 151, you scored 149, you missed it by a couple questions. The program that they use goes and looks at all the questions that you missed and the areas that you missed. When they do that, they also provide, make sure I use the right terms for them, practice items.

[04:23:54] They do an overview of the content. They provide practice items and a knowledge check designated to affirm that they understand the material. So basically, they're teaching this teacher the

curriculum that they missed, and they have them reassess it. They don't take the whole test again, but they take an assessment on the area that they struggled in.

[04:24:14] As long as they meet 75%, we can change it 75 to 80. They have a range in different states. As long as they meet that regard in the first attempt, they are given an alternate pass. If they miss that mark, they have to go and get 100% on the check after more instruction.

[04:24:34] So what this would provide, it would provide for our teachers that are close to passing, not to have to take the entire test and re-demonstrate that they already know the curriculum, that they've already displayed that they know. There'll also be a fairly significant cost savings for teachers in this situation.

[04:24:52] Instead of paying anywhere from $200 to $150 for a Praxis test, they'd only have to pay $50 to Praxis for this experience that they would get to remediate and reassess that area that they struggled in. They don't have this for every area as of right now. I have them listed in the boilerplate, the areas that they do have.

[04:25:12] I also have the ones that are coming very soon. But it is their intention to eventually have all their assessments available on this. It's just a new program, so it takes them a while to do the curriculum and adjustments in those areas. There is one other aspect that I want to mention that they have available.

[04:25:32] It'd be something I would want you all to consider as a board before you made your recommendation. They also have an option, too, where we can do a one-time communication blast to everybody who would fall in this area within the last three years. So that let's say a year ago you took the assessment, you didn't pass and you're either studying still to try to pass it or you decided I just can't pass the test, I'm not going to be a teacher or I'm going to do something different.

[04:25:59] This would communicate out to those people, allow them to do the program and then maybe recover some people that had struggled to pass the assessment the first time. We have the option of whether or not we would want to do that with Virginia. It would be my recommendation that we do.

[04:26:14] I don't see any harm in that since it's only a three-year window that they would take that on. Let's see if there's anything else. This was also discussed with the ABTEL in September. But that's the presentation I have.

[04:26:31] But you also have the slide deck from the presentation from Praxis. Should you like to look at examples of the assessments and maybe a little bit more information, maybe that I rushed through to talk to you today. - Are there any questions here?

[04:26:48] Dr. Northern, do you have a question? - Yeah, I was just wondering, I think I understood it, but so if they, you know, miss it by a couple points, and then there is, if they only miss it in a certain area, what if they, what if it's not easy to say, okay, they missed it with the skill, you know?

[04:27:06] I mean, I guess I'm trying to say like, you know, but it's only gonna be one module, right? you would get pd on and then you would retake like a mini test just based on the module the questions relating to what you missed right so and i think that that's the way i thought of it originally okay but i was wrong when i thought okay because i thought of it just like let's say that there's four modules for the assessment and you did great in the first three and the fourth one is the one you struggled with so you would just do that fourth model but to your question what if it was a little from the fourth a little third little so they create the module

[04:27:40] for the individual oh wow so it's more prescriptive to the areas that they struggled in it's not as simple as just saying module four is your low one let's do the forward now it could be because that could just be how it worked out customizing a new test based on what you've missed that's crazy wow um and how long will they be eligible to take this new test after they there's six months after they've taken the test except for this three-year window that we could do a one-time blast so okay after that that blast you only have six months to do that to take it again and i think part of the

[04:28:15] reason for the shortening of a window like that is because curriculum does change fairly rapidly in some of these subject area tests so you might be you might have missed it on an old test and now we're already on a new test and it's not going to be appropriate to go back and remediate you on an old test thank you i i am so excited i have i think i share your enthusiasm i'm trying to jump out of my seat i mean because we've had teachers visually licensed who just can't get past say the reading we hi we even get send them to tutoring and such and to be able to target the help or

[04:28:50] tutoring in this way um i think it's phenomenal and you know i i hear still from my higher ed colleagues in the field that there's sometimes a feeling in the field that we we put more and more on them without some of those how to like getting them through the teacher licensure programs right they require more require more how can we help them get through and i think this is finally one we can say this is how we're going to help you get through um and with all that said i would love for the board to consider a first and final review of this and move this forward as quickly as possible can i say one more thing i actually actually two quick things one of them um one of

[04:29:29] the exciting things about this is that uh the opportunity for them to take this assessment as opposed to what we currently have where if you failed the assessment and you you continue to teach and you keep tenure like you're on a provisional license a superintendent could waive your assessment. I see this as a better step and probably more comfortable for some superintendents that to have a person at least go through this process as well before they just waive an assessment. So that would be one thing. I also we have with our new math curriculum that this new program would come this could be one of those

[04:30:06] opportunities with the new math curriculum coming out for them to have an alternate I think I used the I wrote down the correct term for in the language but it was let me write it it is oh my goodness I can't remember what it is it's the it's there's a funding source that we have for math curriculum And a creative way to come up with another way to assess math teachers, this could be money that could be used for that as well.

[04:30:44] The math department spoke, reached out to me when they knew I was going to deliver this just to make sure that I was prepared for that as well. So, Dr. Ackerman, is that a motion? Yes, I would like to make a motion that we consider first and final review of this great opportunity for our candidates.

[04:31:03] Mr. Gilstrap, do you have any objection to that? do you feel that we need to? I would like for you to make a decision on the three-year extension if you're going to make that recommendation. Okay. Innovative math teacher credentialing option. Thank you. Okay. So we would want to ensure that the motion contains the three-year extension so um we would waive first review and approve the uh teach advisory board on teacher

[04:31:41] education and licensure's recommendation to approve um the praxis bridge alternative assessment with the three-year extension okay is that sufficient yes i do okay is that good everyone Madam

Chairman, can we add to that also that they'd be allowed to push out a one-time notification to all the individuals.

[04:32:07] That would be what the three-year is. Yeah, that would be the motion. Just want to make sure the notification part was in it. Okay. So we would waive first review. So the motion would be to waive first review and approve the Praxis Bridge Alternative Assessment Program with a three-year extension.

[04:32:26] So Dr. Ackerman made that motion, then Ms. Ashton seconded it. Is there any discussion? Dr. Northern. So if they miss this, I'm just making sure I get it. They miss this passage on the praxis by two point, whatever, within the standard deviation of the mean.

[04:32:45] And then they, within three years, like we're retroactively saying, if you missed it within the last three years, right? So we're going to send back, okay. then you're going to get, you can take this instead of retaking the practice. And then if they pass it then, then they get full. They'll have a passing score. A passing score. If they fail it again, then what happens? Then they're going to just have to keep taking the test.

[04:33:11] They have to keep taking the full test. It's like you can't keep taking customized tests every time you miss a customized test, right? You have to go back to the original full test if you're not within that three years. Okay, got it. That's important. Additional discussion here, questions, Comments? Okay. Dr. Ackerman? Aye. Mr. Green? Aye. Dr. Northern? Aye. Ms. McPherson? Ms. Kilgore? Aye. Ms. Ashton? Aye. Mr. Monk? Aye. And chair votes aye. Thank you. Thank you. Bet you didn't expect that today.

[04:33:54] So that we can hear from board council. Sure. I'm sorry. I don't think my mic was on. Let me say that again. Dr. Northern, would you please read our motion to go into closed meetings so that we can hear from board council?

[04:34:09] Sure. I move that the Virginia Board of Education convene in a closed meeting for the following purposes. Consultation with legal counsel employed by or retained by a public body regarding specific legal matters requiring the provision of legal advice by such personnel pursuant to section 2.23711, section A8 of the Code of Virginia, and that legal counsel to Virginia Board of Education and staff, whose presence will aid in the board's consideration of this matter, participate in the closed meeting.

[04:34:42] Dr. Ackerman. Aye. Mr. Green. Aye. Dr. Northern. Aye. Ms. McPherson. Ms. Kilgore. Aye. Ms. Ashton. Aye. Mr. Monk. Aye. Chair votes aye. We are in closed session. Thank you.

[05:01:45] Session, Dr. Northern, will you read our certification to return to open session?

[05:42:03] Yes. We convened today in a closed meeting pursuant to a recorded vote on the motion above and in accordance with the Freedom of Information Act, Section 2.23712 of the Code of Virginia, requires that the board certify that, to the best of each member's knowledge, one, only public business matters lawfully exempt from open meeting requirements under this chapter, and two, only such public business matters as were identified in the motion by which the closed meeting was convened were heard, discussed, or considered.

[05:42:32] Any member who believes there was a departure from these requirements shall so state prior to the vote, indicating the substance of the departure that, in his or her judgment, has taken place. The statement of the departure will be recorded in the minutes. Dr. Ackerman. Aye.

[05:43:02] Shoot, I didn't turn my mic on. Do I need to go back over that? Okay. Just wanted to say that Ms. McPherson is not here for the certification out.

[05:43:19] she had to leave not too far from the beginning of our closed session so in case that needs to be said for the record uh discussion of current issues does anyone have anything for that particular portion of our agenda today okay superintendent gallickson you don't either i don't either and so with that i will ask um for a motion to adjourn so moved second all right couldn't get we are adjourned